**Aquifer Open Study Notes**

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# Mark

## Mark 1:1

- Mark begins with an introduction. This gospel is about Jesus. In each story in Mark, we should ask, "What is Mark teaching about Jesus in this passage?"
- Gospel: This is a common term in Mark (see 1:14–15; 8:35; 10:29; 13:10; 14:9). It can also be translated as good news. The gospel is the good news about Jesus. See study note on Mark 1:15.
- The Hebrew word mashiakh (Messiah) has the same meaning as the Greek term christos (Christ). Both mean "anointed one."

In the Old Testament, the people of Israel anointed:
- priests (Exodus 28:41; Leviticus 16:32; 21:10),
- kings (2 Samuel 1:14, 16; 19:21; Psalm 2), and
- prophets (1 Kings 19:16).

They anointed them with olive oil to show the Lord's presence, blessing, and authority for the tasks God gave them.

Over time, Israelites increasingly anticipated the Messiah, "the anointed one." He would be a descendant of King David, who would be Israel's king. The political associations of this title in the first century led Jesus to avoid openly declaring himself as the Messiah (see Mark 3:11–12; 8:27–30; 14:61–63; 15:2, 26; John 4:25–26).

- The Son of God: This title emphasizes the special relationship between Jesus and God the Father (Mark 1:11; 9:7; 12:4–6; 14:61–62).

## Mark 1:2–3

- Mark includes Old Testament prophecies (messages from God given long ago) to support his account of the good news about Jesus Christ. John the Baptist's role as a prophet and messenger shows that Jesus is the promised Lord and king. He is the Christ (or Messiah, God's chosen one) and the Son of God.
- Isaiah: Mark follows the Jewish practice of mentioning only the best-known source in a quotation. Here he names Isaiah, even though the quotation also includes (Malachi 3:1; Isaiah 40:3).

## Mark 1:2–8

This account does not focus mainly on John the Baptist, the messenger. Instead, it is about the one whom he announces as Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God (1:1).

## Mark 1:3

John the Baptist was the voice of one calling in the wilderness, urging people to prepare for the Lord's coming. In the book of Isaiah, this prophecy speaks of the coming of the Lord, the God of Israel. Here, it refers to the Lord Jesus (see 12:35–37). The early church called itself "the Way," likely referring to this promise (see Acts 9:2; 19:9, 23; 22:4; 24:14, 22; compare Acts 2:28; 18:25–26; Romans 2:20; 2 Peter 2:2, 21).

## Mark 1:4

- John's mission as the Lord's messenger was to prepare people for the arrival of the Messiah (see Luke 1:76–77). He instructed them to confess their sins, seek God's forgiveness, and be baptized. Those who did this were ready to receive the message of Jesus (see Luke 7:29–30).
- John was in the wilderness, likely the desert area around the Jordan River north of the Dead Sea. This shows he was the "voice" Isaiah mentioned (Mark 1:3).
- preaching a baptism: The exact origin of John's baptism is uncertain. The Qumran community practiced a "baptism" when someone became a part of the community, which they repeated regularly. But John's baptism was a one-time event. Jewish baptism for those converting to Judaism is another possible source, but it is more likely that such baptisms were not practiced until after John's ministry.

## Mark 1:5

All of ... Judea: John the Baptist attracted a lot of attention. Many people believed that there had been no prophet for over 400 years. So, prophets were associated with Israel's past and the future reign of the Messiah.

John preached repentance (turning away from sin and returning to God), like the ancient prophets. He also dressed like the great prophet Elijah (1:6), whom God promised would return in the last days (Malachi 4:5).

## Mark 1:6

- camel's hair, with a leather belt: Compare with Elijah (2 Kings 1:8).
- John ate what was available in the wilderness. Locusts (a type of insect) were allowed as food by God's law (compare Leviticus 11:20–24).

## Mark 1:7

will come one: John knew he was preparing for the coming of the Messiah, but he did not yet know that Jesus was the Messiah (see Luke 7:18–23).

## Mark 1:8

John's baptism prepared people for God's kingdom by calling them to repentance. The baptism of Jesus brought the gift of the Holy Spirit, through whom sinful people become God's children (Romans 8:15–16; 1 Corinthians 12:13; Galatians 4:6).

## Mark 1:9

- At this time, Jesus lived in Nazareth, a small town in lower Galilee (Matthew 2:19–23; Luke 2:39). Jesus soon left Nazareth for Capernaum, a city on the Sea of Galilee (Matthew 4:13).
- was baptized by John: Matthew 3:14–15 explains the reason Jesus received the baptism of repentance.

## Mark 1:10

- The phrase the heavens breaking open shows that Jesus has a unique and direct relationship with God the Father. In Mark 15:38, the same verb shows that believers also gain access to God through the death of Jesus.
- All four Gospels mention the Holy Spirit coming down on Jesus like a dove. The Spirit, who was active in the first creation, now works with Jesus to begin the new creation (Genesis 1:2; Romans 8:15–17; 1 Corinthians 6:11; Ephesians 1:13–14; 2 Thessalonians 2:13).

## Mark 1:11

You are My beloved Son: By age twelve, Jesus was aware of his unique relationship with God the Father (Luke 2:49).

## Mark 1:12–13

- the Spirit drove Jesus (compare Matthew 4:1; Luke 4:1): he Spirit led Jesus into the wilderness. From the beginning of his ministry, Jesus defeated Satan and resisted temptation. His later acts of casting out demons (Mark 1:21–34; 3:11–12; 5:1–20; 9:14–27) show the results of that victory (see 3:27).
- Jesus was tempted in the wilderness of Judea. In Scripture, the wilderness often has a sense of danger and evil because of Satan and wild animals (Isaiah 13:19–22; Ezekiel 34:25). These animals included dogs, wolves, leopards, jackals, and bears.
- The forty days remind us of Israel's forty years of testing in the wilderness. Israel failed, but Jesus succeeded. He resisted temptation without sinning (Hebrews 2:18; 4:15; see also James 1:3, 12; 1 Peter 1:7; Revelation 2:10).

## Mark 1:14

Jesus began his ministry after John was arrested by Herod Antipas (the ruler of Galilee). There was some overlap between their ministries (John 3:22–24; 4:1–2), but most of the ministry of Jesus happened after John's.

John belongs mainly to the old order (the time before the full ministry of Jesus; Matthew 11:7–14), while Jesus brings the new. Both men carried out God's plan, and both were arrested and put to death (Mark 6:14–29; 9:31; 10:33).

Jesus started preaching in Galilee after John's arrest. But John 2:13–4:43 suggests Jesus had an earlier ministry in Judea.

## Mark 1:14–15

This summary introduces 1:14–3:6. Such summaries help hearers understand what follows (see also 3:7–12; 6:6). Most of Mark's original audience would have heard the Gospel read aloud.

## Mark 1:15

- The preaching of Jesus is summarized in his announcement that the kingdom of God had come. He called people to repent (turn away from sin and turn to God) and believe the good news about the Messiah (1:1).
- The kingdom of God is not associated with a place or land. It began with Jesus himself and continues through his followers.
- Because the kingdom of God has come, people must repent and have faith in God's good news. In the time of Jesus, this good news meant that God's reign had arrived through the Messiah. For Mark's later audience, it also included the news of the death, resurrection, ascension of Jesus, and his promised return (15:1–16:8).

All people, both Jews and non-Jews (called Gentiles), need God's forgiveness through repentance and faith in Jesus.

## Mark 1:16–20

The call of the two pairs of brothers (Simon and Andrew, and James and John) came after they had already met Jesus earlier (John 1:35–42).

## Mark 1:17

Mark uses the invitation of Jesus, Come, follow Me (1:20; 8:34) and the repeated idea of people following him (1:18; 2:14–15; 3:7; 5:24) to describe what it means to be his disciple (see "Following Jesus" Theme Note).

## Mark 1:19–20

James son of Zebedee and his brother John ... left their father Zebedee: Jesus later taught that his followers would do similar things (8:34–35; Matthew 10:37–39).

## Mark 1:21

Mark begins his first account of an exorcism (driving or casting out an evil spirit) with Jesus and his companions going into the synagogue in Capernaum. Jesus teaching there suggests that he was already known as a teacher, so he was invited to speak (compare Acts 13:15).

## Mark 1:21–28

Jesus driving out evil spirits shows who he is and his power over Satan (see study notes on Mark 1:12–13 and 3:27; see also 1:34, 39; 3:11–12, 22; 5:1–20; 6:13; 7:24–30; 9:14–29).

## Mark 1:22

The teachers of religious law were professional scribes (scholars who taught, copied, and interpreted Jewish law for the people). They were primarily associated with the Pharisees. The authority of the scribes came from quoting other scribes (compare Matthew 5:21–48). When Jesus taught, the people were amazed because he spoke and acted with real authority (see Mark 1:27; 5:20; 6:2; 7:37; 10:24–32; 11:18; 15:5).

## Mark 1:23–24

- The demon spoke through the man who was possessed by an evil spirit (1:24). In the Gospels, demons are often associated with disease (9:17, 27; Matthew 17:15) and self-destructive behavior (Mark 1:26; 5:2–5; 9:17–18, 20–22).

Demons know who Jesus is (1:34). They constantly identify him as the Holy One of God (for similar phrases see 3:11; 5:7).

- In saying us, the evil spirit spoke on behalf of all demons. It recognized that Jesus has full authority and understood that he had come to oppose and destroy evil.

## Mark 1:25

- Jesus did not need to shout or use magic words. He spoke with the authority of the Son of God, and the evil spirit obeyed (1:1).
- Be silent!: Jesus commanded the evil spirit not to reveal his identity. This is an example of the "messianic secret." This term describes places in Mark where Jesus tells demons or people not to reveal who he is (1:25, 34; 3:11–12; 8:30; 9:9).

## Mark 1:26

The loud shriek and convulsions caused by the unclean spirit were cries of defeat as it left the man (see also 1:27; 5:13; 9:26; compare 15:37).

## Mark 1:27–28

- The amazement caused by this exorcism quickly led to the spread of the news about Jesus.
- What is this? A new teaching with authority!: People saw the healings and exorcisms that Jesus did as being part of his teaching (1:21–22, 27; compare 1:38–39; 3:14–15; 6:2, 5, 12–13, 30).

## Mark 1:29–30

Simon, also called Peter, was married (see 1 Corinthians 9:5).

## Mark 1:31

Jesus healed Simon's mother-in-law immediately (see also 1:40–45; 2:1–12; 3:1–6; 5:25–34; 7:31–37; 8:22–26; 10:46–52).

## Mark 1:32–34

These public healings happened after sunset, following the Sabbath day (1:21, 29). Many people witnessed them (see also 1:39; 3:10–11; 6:5, 53–56).

## Mark 1:33

Jesus became more popular with the crowds (also in 1:37, 39, 45). Meanwhile, the leaders increasingly rejected him (2:1–3:6).

## Mark 1:34

they knew who He was: See 1:23–25.

## Mark 1:35

Despite his busy ministry, Jesus made time to pray (6:46; 14:32–39). Mark emphasizes how important prayer was in the life of Jesus (see also Luke 3:21; 6:12; 9:18, 28–29; 11:1–4; 18:1; 22:32).

## Mark 1:38–39

- Prayer equipped Jesus to preach, teach, heal, and drive out demons (1:35).
- The mission of Jesus in Galilee focused on preaching in the synagogues, where he took the opportunity to speak (1:21; Luke 4:16–30). The apostle Paul later

took advantage of this same opportunity (Acts 13:5, 14–15; 14:1; 16:13; 17:1).
- Jesus relied on the Jewish practice of kindness to strangers when he traveled (compare Mark 6:10; Genesis 18:1–8; 19:1–8; Luke 10:7; Hebrews 13:2; 3 John 1:5–8).
- The region of Galilee measured about 65 kilometers (40 miles) north to south and 40 kilometers (25 miles) east to west. In the time of Jesus, Galilee was ruled by Herod Antipas.

## Mark 1:40

Leprosy refers to several skin diseases (or even mildew in a building). An infected person was considered ceremonially unclean and was excluded from family and society (Leviticus 13:45–46; Numbers 12:9–12; 2 Chronicles 26:16–21; Luke 17:12).

## Mark 1:41

Jesus was willing to touch a ceremonially unclean leper. This act shows the new order of the kingdom of God (1:15; 5:25–34; Luke 7:36–50; see Matthew 10:8; 11:5).

## Mark 1:43–45

- Jesus instructed the man to visit the priest to confirm his healing and make the required sacrificial offering. This would act as public proof of his healing.
- Despite the severe warning Jesus gave, the man went and told people what happened to him. As a result, Jesus could not enter the town and had to preach in more remote places. Jesus became widely known, and people from many places came to see him (3:7–8).

## Mark 2:1

He was home: See Matthew 4:13. The large crowd shows that Jesus was popular.

## Mark 2:1–12

This controversy story is also a miracle story. It includes both a dispute and an act of healing or power.

Because it contains a miracle, it connects with the earlier group of miracle stories in 1:21–45.

## Mark 2:1–3.6

Five controversy stories (2:1–12, 13–17, 18–22, 23–28; 3:1–6) are grouped together because they share a common theme. Each story shows a conflict between Jesus and the religious leaders. In these accounts, Jesus says or does things that challenge their beliefs and practices. These stories show the great authority that Jesus has.

## Mark 2:4

- through the crowd: See 2:1.
- Houses at that time usually had flat roofs made of mud, thatch (dry plant material), and branches. The men made an opening by digging through the roof.

## Mark 2:5

- Jesus saw the faith of the paralytic and the four men who brought him.
- your sins are forgiven: Those listening understood the words of Jesus as a claim to having the same authority as God (see 2:6–10; Luke 7:48–49).

## Mark 2:6–7

Only God can forgive sins, yet Jesus had authority to do so (2:10).

## Mark 2:9–11

Which is easier: to say ... 'Your sins are forgiven': This claim cannot be directly proved or disproved, while the claim to heal can be. Jesus showed his ability to heal in order to show his authority to forgive.

## Mark 2:12

We have never seen anything like this!: Mark often shows how Jesus amazed people (1:22, 27; 4:41; 6:50–51).

## Mark 2:13–15

- Levi was also called Matthew (see Matthew 9:9–10). Certain people are known by two names in the New Testament (for example, Simon is also called Peter; Saul is also called Paul; Judas son of James is also called Thaddaeus, see study note on Mark 3:18).
- This type of tax collector (Greek telōnēs) collected sales taxes, customs, and road tolls, unlike those who collected the poll tax (12:14). Other Jews disliked local tax collectors like Levi because they often charged the public more than they owed (Luke 19:8). As agents of the Romans, the Jews considered them to be traitors. Jesus invited Levi, a tax collector, to follow him, joining Peter, Andrew, James, and John (Mark 1:16–20).

## Mark 2:13–17

This controversy is about Jesus spending time with sinners who had a bad reputation, such as tax collectors, and eating with them.

## Mark 2:16

The Pharisees, who were teachers of religious law, regarded Jesus eating with sinners as him accepting them as friends (Luke 15:1–2; 19:5, 7; Acts 11:2–18; Galatians 2:11–12). Jesus showed that these tax collectors and sinners were welcome in the kingdom of God.

In his ministry, Jesus invited both Jews and Gentiles to share in the kingdom of God (Mark 5:1–20; 7:24–30; compare Matthew 8:5–13; Luke 7:1–10; John 4:43–54).

## Mark 2:17

Jesus answered his opponents with a well-known proverb. He compared himself to a doctor and sinners to sick people. Salvation is for those who know they are sinners, not for those who think they are righteous (Luke 16:15; 18:9; Romans 3:23).

## Mark 2:18–22

This controversy deals with fasting, which Jesus did not practice with his disciples. The Pharisees regularly fasted two days a week, on Mondays and Thursdays (Luke 18:12). Jews often fasted when mourning or specially seeking the Lord's favor (Leviticus 16:29–31; 1 Samuel 31:13; 2 Samuel 1:12; 12:21–23; Ezra 8:23; Esther 4:3; Matthew 6:16).

## Mark 2:19–20

Jesus was like a bridegroom at his wedding, so fasting was not appropriate. It was a time to celebrate (Luke 15:23–25, 32). The disciples would fast after Jesus went up to heaven (see Acts 13:2–3; 14:23).

## Mark 2:21–22

The old customs of the old covenant do not fit with the new arrival of God's kingdom. People know that a patch of unshrunk cloth sewn on old clothing will tear the old cloth as it shrinks. In the same way, cracking old wineskins will burst when new wine ferments in them. The fasting of the old ways cannot be mixed with the feasting that comes with the new.

## Mark 2:23–28

In this controversy, Jesus and his disciples are accused of breaking the Sabbath (Exodus 20:8–11). Picking grain by hand in another person's field was lawful (Deuteronomy 23:25). The charge was that by rubbing the chaff from the kernels, the disciples were working on the Sabbath, which was forbidden (Exodus 34:21).

## Mark 2:25–26

Jesus answered by referring to an event in the life of King David (1 Samuel 21). David and his men ate the sacred bread, the twelve loaves in the tabernacle that only priests were allowed to eat (see Leviticus 24:5–9). In that sense, they did what the law did not permit. But Jesus showed that a deeper principle was also at work (Mark 2:27–28).

## Mark 2:27–28

Since Jesus is the Lord of humanity (1 Corinthians 15:25–28; Ephesians 1:20–22; Philippians 2:9–11) and since the Sabbath was made to meet the needs of people, Jesus is Lord even of the Sabbath. Like when Jesus claimed authority to forgive sins, this also showed that he claimed authority that belongs to God (Mark 2:7).

## Mark 3:1–2

The scene again involves a synagogue, probably in Capernaum (1:21, 29). The man with a withered hand was present on the Sabbath (3:1–2). The enemies of Jesus wanted to use this situation against him. If he healed the man, they could accuse him, so they watched him closely.

## Mark 3:1–6

This story ends the collection of controversy stories (2:1–3:6). Like the previous story, Jesus argues with the Pharisees about the Sabbath. As in the first story, the controversy involves a healing (2:1–12).

## Mark 3:3–4

- Jesus challenged his enemies' belief that God did not allow doing good works on the Sabbath (see Luke 13:10–17).
- to save life or to destroy it: This might refer to an incident in which the Maccabees decided to fight if attacked on the Sabbath (1 Maccabees 2:32–41). These great Jewish heroes were willing to kill on the Sabbath day. But the Pharisees did not allow good works on that day. The question Jesus asked embarrassed them. It shamed them into silence, but they still refused to change (Mark 3:5).

## Mark 3:5–6

Those who opposed Jesus were stubborn and would not listen to good reasoning. Instead of changing, they began to plan how to kill him (see also 11:18; 12:12; 14:1–2, 10–11).

## Mark 3:7–12

- Jesus went to the lake (the Sea of Galilee), which prepares for the events in 4:1–5:43. The large crowd that came to see John the Baptist (1:7) was smaller than the crowd that came to see Jesus.
- Idumea was a region in southern Judea, settled by the Edomites after the exile in Babylon.
- Tyre and Sidon were Phoenician cities on the Mediterranean coast that Jesus later visited (7:24, 31).

## Mark 3:9

The boat likely belonged to Peter and Andrew or James and John. The crowd wanted to see Jesus so much that he needed to avoid being crushed by the people (4:1; 5:24, 31).

## Mark 3:10

Jesus healed many people that day. He might have healed all the sick (see Matthew 12:15).

## Mark 3:11–12

The unclean spirits knew who Jesus was (1:34; see also 1:22; 5:7). But Jesus did not want people to know his identity.

## Mark 3:13–19

The scene shifts to a mountain. Mark describes how Jesus called his disciples to come to him. This is similar to God's call to Old Testament prophets (Exodus 3:14–22; 1 Samuel 3:4–14; Jeremiah 1:5–19).

## Mark 3:14–15

Jesus chose 12 men to represent Israel's 12 tribes and to announce that the kingdom of God had arrived. He called them apostles. The Greek word apostoloi refers to people sent on a special mission.

Jesus chose them to travel with him and to be sent out (Greek apostellō) to preach and cast out demons. They represented Jesus and had his authority.

## Mark 3:16–18

- Simon and Andrew were brothers, just like James and John (1:16–20).
- Peter is the Greek version of the Aramaic word kepa', which means "rock."

## Mark 3:17

whom He named Boanerges, meaning "Sons of Thunder": This likely describes their character. It may suggest strong emotions, boldness, or quick reactions. For example, they once wanted to call down fire on a village that rejected Jesus (see Luke 9:53–54).

## Mark 3:18

Philip is fifth on all four lists of the twelve disciples (Matthew 10:1–4; Luke 6:12–16; Acts 1:13). James son of Alphaeus (not the son of Zebedee and brother of John) is always ninth. Bartholomew might be Nathanael (John 1:43–51). Matthew is probably Levi, the tax collector (Mark 2:14; Matthew 9:9). Thomas is also called Didymus (a Greek word meaning "twin," John 11:16; 20:24; 21:2). The New Testament does not explain this name further. Thaddaeus is missing from Luke's list (Matthew 10:3). He might be Judas, the son of James (Luke 6:16; Acts 1:13).

The presence of a government official (Matthew) and an anti-government activist (Simon the Zealot) among the twelve apostles shows the ability of Jesus to change people and overcome the natural hostility between them.

## Mark 3:19

- Identifying Judas as Iscariot suggests that Mark wanted to avoid confusing him with another Judas (Luke 6:16; Acts 1:13). The name Iscariot likely comes from the Hebrew phrase 'ish qeriyoth, meaning "man of Kerioth" (a town in Judea).
- who betrayed Jesus: See Mark 14:10–11, 43–46.

## Mark 3:20

Jesus and his disciples could not even find time to eat. This shows how large the crowds were and how popular Jesus had become (3:7–9).

## Mark 3:20–35

This story about Jesus and his family (3:20–21 and 31–35) surrounds a controversy story about Jesus driving out demons (3:22–30). This arrangement connects his family with the religious leaders, since both groups misunderstand him and stand against him.

## Mark 3:21

He is out of his mind: Mark does not explain whether the attempt by the family of Jesus to seize him was motivated by sincere but misguided concern, or by hostility. The brothers and sisters of Jesus were not among his followers until after his resurrection (3:31–35; John 7:3–5). First Corinthians 15:7 mentions James, the brother of Jesus, who became a leader of the Jerusalem church (Acts 15:13–21).

### Mark 3:22

The scribes ... from Jerusalem claimed Jesus was crazy because they believed Satan possessed him (see study note on 1:22) (Greek Beelzeboul; see study note on Matthew 10:25). The opponents of Jesus said his ability to perform miracles came from Satan (see the Jewish rabbinic work, Sanhedrin 3:43a, where they credit the working of miracles to magic).

### Mark 3:23–27

Jesus showed that this charge made no sense by using several examples. Satan would not work against himself.

### Mark 3:27

Jesus explained his power to drive out demons by saying someone stronger than Satan had arrived and could take control of Satan's house (1:7). Jesus, the Messiah and the Son of God, was introducing God's kingdom and rescuing people from Satan's power (1:1).

### Mark 3:28–30

- The phrase Truly I tell you often introduces the sayings of Jesus and emphasizes their importance (see also 8:12; 9:1, 41; 10:15, 29; 11:23; 12:43; 13:30; 14:9, 18, 25, 30).
- the sons of men will be forgiven all sins and blasphemies: One sin has eternal consequences. This is blasphemy against the Holy Spirit. To blaspheme the Holy Spirit means attributing the work of God to an unclean spirit (an evil spirit). Resisting and rejecting God's work in this way prevents the convicting work of the Spirit, which leads to repentance, faith in God, and forgiveness of sin (see study notes on Matthew 12:31–32; compare Hebrews 6:4–6; 1 John 5:16–17).

### Mark 3:31–35

- Mark returns to the story from 3:20–21.
- Your mother and brothers: Many people understand the brothers of Jesus to be children born to Joseph and Mary after Jesus was born (see also 6:3; Matthew 1:25; 12:46; John 19:26–27). Some interpreters think they were Joseph's children from an earlier marriage or the cousins of Jesus. They hold this view because of the Roman Catholic belief that Mary remained a virgin for her whole life.

### Mark 3:33–34

In God's Kingdom, one's true relatives are determined not by blood but by a faith relationship (see also 10:29–30).

### Mark 3:35

Doing God's will includes repentance from sin, faith in God, and following Jesus (1:15, 18, 20).

### Mark 4:1

Jesus again uses a boat to avoid the press of the crowd when he is teaching (3:9; Luke 5:2–3).

### Mark 4:1–34

In this section, Mark gathers several teaching parables of Jesus. A parable is a short story that teaches a spiritual truth.

### Mark 4:2

Parables are often stories (Luke 15:11–32; 18:1–8) but can also be:

- proverbs (short, wise sayings that teach a general truth; Mark 3:24–25; Luke 4:23),
- similes and metaphors (Matthew 5:14; 10:16),
- riddles (Mark 7:15; 14:58),
- comparisons (Matthew 13:33; Luke 15:3–7),
- examples (Luke 10:30–35; 12:16–21), or
- allegories (metaphors with specific symbols representing each part of the story; Mark 4:3–9; 12:1–12).

### Mark 4:3–9

The collection begins with the longest parable and its interpretation (4:13–20). The different types of soil represent different ways people respond to God's message.

### Mark 4:10

The scene changes from Jesus teaching a large crowd from a boat to being alone with the Twelve and those around Him. They ask Jesus about all the parables (4:33–34), not just this one.

### Mark 4:11–12

- The true followers of Jesus could understand the secret of the kingdom of God. They knew the kingdom had arrived (1:14–15). They knew that the Christ, the Son of God, was among them (1:1). To those on the outside, it seemed like riddles.
- When Jesus answered the disciples' question, he showed that he used parables to keep outsiders from understanding. This was so that they would be unable to repent and be forgiven.

The quotation from Isaiah 6:9–10 in the Greek Old Testament version implies this was a deliberate judgment on the hearers. Jesus taught in parables, and outsiders

did not believe. This fulfilled what the Scriptures had said would happen.
The teaching of Jesus about the Kingdom of God was sensitive (it could sound like a political threat and worry Roman rulers). Because of this, teaching in parables helped make his message less likely to cause conflict.

## Mark 4:13

If people who heard Jesus could not understand the parable, they might not receive the gift of belonging to God's Kingdom. But even his own disciples needed Jesus to explain the parables.

## Mark 4:14–20

The explanation of the parable of the four soils uses an allegory (a story where each part has a deeper meaning). The farmer represents someone who shares God's word (4:14). The four types of soil represent different ways people respond to that message.

The main point of the parable is that people should be like good soil and listen to God's word (4:9). Only those who produce a crop (show a changed life) and continue faithfully to the end will be saved (13:13; 8:35; Revelation 2:10–11).

## Mark 4:21

A lamp is lit to shine and provide light, not to stay hidden. Citizens of the kingdom of God must display the light of the good news about Jesus (4:17).

## Mark 4:21–25

These sayings connect with the call to listen carefully (4:9, 23–24) and with the difference between insiders and outsiders (4:11–12, 24–25). They show how people in God's kingdom will live.

## Mark 4:22–23

One day, the lamp (that is, Jesus; compare John 8:12) will reveal everything hidden. This includes every thought and secret action (Mark 13:26; 14:62; see Philippians 2:10–11). The time to listen is now, before this happens (Mark 4:9).

## Mark 4:24

Those who listen and respond will gain more understanding. But "those on the outside" (4:11–12) will experience greater darkness (2 Corinthians 3:14–16).

## Mark 4:26–29

- This parable focuses on the seed and how it grows over time.
- Just as the earth produces crops on its own, the completion (final coming) of God's kingdom does not depend on human effort.
- first the stalk, then the head, then the grain that ripens within: These describe the normal stages of a seed's growth.

## Mark 4:26–34

Mark now gives additional seed parables (see 4:3–20). They all focus on "the mystery of the kingdom of God" (4:11). The parables of the seed growing secretly (4:26–29) and the mustard seed (4:30–32) show different stages of seed growth.

The kingdom of God is hidden (4:21). But growth is certain (4:26–29). The outcome will be great (4:32).

## Mark 4:29

Harvest time is like the final coming of God's kingdom. A sickle often represents the final judgment (Jeremiah 50:16; Joel 3:13; Revelation 14:14–19).

## Mark 4:30–32

Jesus contrasts a very small beginning with a large result. The mustard seed was known to be very small, almost the smallest seed people commonly used (see Matthew 17:20).

## Mark 4:33–34

- Mark's summary of this section shows that 4:3–32 is a collection of parables. It is not a record of what Jesus taught on one specific day in the order in which he taught it.
- Jesus privately explained the parables to the disciples. This shows that they were not outsiders, even though they sometimes did not understand (compare 4:13).

## Mark 4:35–41

- This passage focuses on the greatness of Jesus Christ, the Son of God. The authority of Jesus over the forces of nature showed that he is divine (truly God).
- the other side: The eastern side of the Sea of Galilee was the region of the Gerasenes (5:1).
- The presence of other boats following him shows how popular Jesus had become.

## Mark 4:35–5.43

The three miracle stories in this section are connected by:

- a shared location (the Sea of Galilee),
- the presence of the disciples,
- the use of a boat, and
- a common theme, "Who is this" (4:41).

## Mark 4:38

Jesus was likely asleep at the back of the boat, using a sandbag as a pillow. In 1986, archaeologists found a boat from the time of Jesus in the mud near the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee. It is 8 meters long (26.5 feet), 2.2 meters wide (7.5 feet), and 1.37 meters deep (4.5 feet). It has a raised stern. It could hold up to 15 people.

## Mark 4:39–40

The disciples still lacked faith in Jesus (4:41), even though they had many chances to experience his power and authority (1:21–34, 40–45; 2:1–12; 3:1–5).

## Mark 4:41

- The disciples were very afraid. This is a common response to Jesus in Mark (5:15, 33; 6:50; 9:32; 10:32; 11:18; 16:8).
- Who is this: Mark's audience already knows that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God (1:1, 11, 24; 3:11).

## Mark 5:1

in the region of the Gerasenes: The exact location is uncertain because of differences in the manuscripts and geography.

Manuscript evidence supports Gerasa, a city in this region located 59.5 kilometers (37 miles) southeast of the Sea of Galilee (5:13).

Some manuscripts read Gadarenes. Gadara was eight kilometers (five miles) southeast of the Sea of Galilee.

A few manuscripts read Gergesenes. The town of Gergesa was on a steep bank on the Sea of Galilee's eastern shore.

## Mark 5:1–20

Jesus and the disciples reached the other side of the lake, finishing the journey started in 4:35. As in 1:21–28 and 3:11, the demons recognized that Jesus was the Son of the Most High God (1:34). For the first time in the Gospel of Mark, a Gentile was healed by Jesus (see study note on 5:10–13; compare 7:24–30).

## Mark 5:2–5

Mark focuses on Jesus. The evil spirit was strong, but Jesus had even greater authority (5:6–13).

## Mark 5:6–8

- Despite the man's terrible condition, the arrival of Jesus gave him hope. He ran and knelt before Jesus, asking for help.
- Son of the Most High God: Evil spirits know who Jesus really is (1:24, 34; 3:11).
- There was no struggle. Jesus was in control, and the unclean spirit obeyed him. Torture is the final judgment awaiting unclean spirits (Matthew 8:29; Luke 8:31).

## Mark 5:9

A legion was a Roman military unit of 5,000–6,000 men. Here it describes the presence of many evil spirits.

## Mark 5:10–13

The spirits kept begging Jesus, which shows his authority over them. Jesus allowed them to enter a herd of about 2,000 pigs. The pigs show that this was Gentile (non-Jewish) territory.

Some people focus on the loss of the pigs or ask why Jesus allowed the demons to destroy them. But Mark and his audience focused on how Jesus saved the man.

## Mark 5:15–16

The change in the man shows the power Jesus has to save. Before, the man had been controlled by evil spirits. Now he was restored.

## Mark 5:17

The frightened people asked Jesus to go away. Fear and amazement are frequent responses to the mighty acts of Jesus (see 1:22, 27; 2:12; 4:41; 6:50–51). People reacted in different ways to the saving work of Jesus (see 4:14–20).

## Mark 5:18

Unlike his neighbors, the man experienced God's grace and wanted to go with Him (literally that he might be with him; see 3:14).

## Mark 5:19–20

- Jesus wanted the man to tell others about the great things the Lord had done for him. Thus, Mark identifies Jesus as the Lord.

- tell them how much: Unlike other times, Jesus did not hide his identity, possibly because it was safer in this non-Jewish area (see 3:11–12).
- the Decapolis: See study note on Matthew 4:24–25.

### Mark 5:21–22

When Jesus had again crossed by boat to the other side ... A synagogue leader named Jairus arrived: Jairus organized the worship services at the synagogue and represented the Jewish community to the outside world (compare Acts 13:15).

### Mark 5:21–43

Two healing miracles are connected by the need for faith (5:34, 36). The story of Jairus's daughter begins, then the account of the woman with constant bleeding comes in the middle (5:25–34), and then the story of Jairus's daughter continues. This pattern places the two stories together and connects them (see Mark Book Introduction, "Literary Features"). During the delay caused by the woman's healing, Jairus's daughter died (5:35–43).

### Mark 5:23

The father wanted Jesus to heal her physically (Greek so that she might be saved; see 3:4; 5:28, 34; 6:56; 10:52; 15:30–31).

### Mark 5:24–34

As Jesus heads to Jairus's home, followed by a large crowd, Mark introduces a woman in the crowd who suffers from constant bleeding. This condition not only harms her health but also makes her ceremonially unclean. This prevents her from participating in normal community life (see Leviticus 15:25–27). She is an example of the faith that Jairus should have.

### Mark 5:27–29

The woman's faith led her to believe that touching the clothing that Jesus was wearing would heal her, and it happened right away (5:34).

### Mark 5:33–34

The woman felt afraid, not because she was guilty, but because she realized she had witnessed a powerful miracle from God. Unlike the fear of the people in the region of the Gerasenes (5:15–17), her fear was positive and led to Jesus blessing her. She experienced God's grace and salvation.

### Mark 5:35–43

Since Jairus had left home, his daughter had died. Jesus reassured Jairus that, despite the death of his daughter and the seeming hopelessness of the situation, Jairus should not be afraid but have faith in Jesus.

### Mark 5:36

just believe: Like the woman did (5:28).

### Mark 5:37

Peter, James, and John became the closest followers of Jesus (see 3:16–17; 9:2; 14:33).

### Mark 5:38

the commotion ... weeping and wailing loudly: These things the messengers' report and emphasized the hopelessness of the situation. Such displays of grief were common at funerals in the time of Jesus, where people often hired professionals to sadly cry (see Matthew 9:23).

### Mark 5:39

Sleep is a metaphor for death (John 11:11; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–15). The child is not dead because Jesus will resurrect her. She is only asleep and will soon "wake up" and continue her life. The same Greek word translated here as asleep refers to death in Matthew 27:52; Acts 7:60; 13:36; 1 Corinthians 15:6, 18, 20, 51; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–15.

### Mark 5:40

The crowd did not understand what Jesus meant. They laughed at him, knowing the girl had died. He made them all leave, probably to keep them from discouraging the parents any further.

### Mark 5:41

Mark translates Talitha koum for his Greek-speaking audience as "Little girl, I say to you, get up!" These Aramaic words are not magical. They are simply what Jesus said when he raised the girl. Aramaic was his native language. Mark likely learned the story in Aramaic while in Jerusalem.

### Mark 5:42

Jesus showed his power over death when the little girl stood up and walked immediately. She did not need time to recover. The change was instant and complete.

## Mark 5:43

- After the miracle, there is a command not to tell anyone about it (see 3:11–12).
- give her something to eat: The Lord, who controls creation, demons, illness, and death, also cares about the daily needs of his creatures.

## Mark 6:1–2

- The teaching of Jesus amazed the people because of his wisdom and his ability to heal and drive out demons.
- "Where did this man get": His early life in Nazareth had not prepared them to accept him as a teacher and healer who spoke and acted with authority.

## Mark 6:1–6

Nazareth's rejection of Jesus stands in sharp contrast to the faith shown by others. The few miracles he did there also contrast with the greater displays of power seen in other places.

## Mark 6:3–4

- The people of Nazareth saw Jesus only as a carpenter (literally craftsman).
- He is just a carpenter, the son of Mary: Calling Jesus the son of Mary instead of the son of Joseph likely means Joseph had died by then.
- brother ... his sisters: See study note on 3:31–35.
- They were very offended: They believed Jesus was pretending to be someone he could not possibly be.

## Mark 6:5–6

- Faith and healing are often connected in Mark (2:5; 5:34, 36; 9:23–24; 10:52). The miracles of Jesus were not performances but miraculous signs of God's kingdom. To enter this kingdom and receive its benefits, one must repent and have faith (1:15).
- Jesus healed some sick people, but the lack of faith in his own village amazed Jesus. This was unusual.
- This part of Mark describes Jesus being rejected by (3:7–6:6a):
- his family (3:21, 31–35),
- the scribes (3:22), and
- the people of Gerasa (5:17).

It ends with rejection by people in his hometown (6:1–6a).

Along the way, a few people believed and Jesus healed them. This ending is similar to the end of the previous section (1:14–3:6).

## Mark 6:6

This summary of the healing and preaching ministry of Jesus leads to a story about the disciples. Jesus likely taught from village to village near the Sea of Galilee, and perhaps in Capernaum (see 2:1).

## Mark 6:6–8.21

The mission of Jesus and the misunderstanding of the disciples are prominent themes in this section.

## Mark 6:7

- two by two: This practice fulfilled the Old Testament rule of needing two witnesses (Numbers 35:30; Deuteronomy 17:6; 19:15; see Matthew 18:16). It also allowed for them to have companionship and mutual help Acts 13:1–3; 15:22, 39, 40).
- giving them authority: Jesus can give his authority to others (see Mark 1:27; 2:10).
- Jesus told the disciples to drive out unclean spirits and to preach and heal (6:12–13; see 6:30).

## Mark 6:7–13

Jesus sent the disciples to preach and heal. During this mission, they memorized the teachings of Jesus by repeating them. This prepared them to later recall and share what Jesus did and taught (Luke 1:2).

## Mark 6:8–9

The instructions for the disciples' mission focused on what they should leave behind (bread ...bag ...money ... second tunic). They were to travel with little and rely on Jewish kindness to strangers for food and a place to sleep at night (see Luke 22:35–37).

## Mark 6:10

They were to sleep in the same house and not take advantage of kindness of their hosts by looking for better food and another place to sleep at night.

## Mark 6:11

shake the dust off your feet: This represents God's judgment on those who rejected the apostles' message (see Acts 18:6). To reject it was actually to reject Jesus and God, who sent him (9:37).

## Mark 6:12–13

The call to repent is a short form of the fuller message in 1:15.

## Mark 6:14

- Jesus' name had become well known: The successful mission in Galilee and Perea by six teams of disciples helped spread news about him throughout the region (6:12–13).
- John the Baptist has risen from the dead!: King Herod may have thought that John the Baptist had come back to life and was now working through Jesus. This idea is similar to how Elijah's spirit came upon Elisha.

Or, he might have been expressing frustration, saying something like, "This is John the Baptist all over again!" (the same kind of powerful prophet has appeared again).

## Mark 6:14–29

The story of John the Baptist's death, placed between the disciples' mission and return, emphasizes the authority and power of Jesus (see 6:7, 14). John's end and the warning to the disciples during their mission also point ahead to the death of Jesus (6:11). The one greater even than John (1:8) would soon be handed over to religious and political leaders and put to death (8:31; 9:31; 10:33).

## Mark 6:15

The return of the prophet Elijah had been prophesied in Malachi 3:1 and 4:5–6 (see also Mark 9:11–13).

## Mark 6:17

- that John be arrested and bound and imprisoned: The Jewish historian Josephus (Antiquities 18.5.2) says that John was imprisoned in the fortress of Machaerus in Perea.
- Josephus (Antiquities 18.5.1–4) also mentions that Herodias was the wife of Herod Antipas's half-brother, Herod Philip.

## Mark 6:18

- Mark explains the moral and religious reason for the arrest and execution of John the Baptist. The Jewish historian Josephus gives a political reason instead. He says Herod feared that John's popularity might lead to a rebellion (Josephus, Antiquities 18.5.2).

In a similar way, the charges against Jesus began as religious concerns (Mark 14:63–64). But when he was brought before Pontius Pilate, the charges became political (15:2; Luke 23:2–3).

- It is not lawful: John said that Herod's marriage was wrong. It was adultery (Leviticus 20:10). It also broke the law that forbids a man from marrying his brother's wife (Leviticus 18:16; 20:21).

## Mark 6:19–28

Herodias's role in John the Baptist's murder is similar to the story of Jezebel (1 Kings 19:1–2). Like Jezebel, she pushed for the death of a prophet.

Herod gave in to pressure (Mark 6:26–28). This points ahead to what Pontius Pilate later did. Pilate ordered that Jesus be put to death even though he believed Jesus was innocent (compare 6:20, 25–28 with 15:6–15).

## Mark 6:22

the daughter of Herodias: The first-century Jewish historian Josephus wrote that Herodias's daughter was also named Salome (Josephus, Antiquities 18.5.4).

## Mark 6:29

This verse is similar to the description of the death and burial of Jesus (see 15:43–46). Disciples of John existed after his death until at least the AD 200s (see Acts 18:24–19:7).

## Mark 6:30

- Mark refers to the disciples of Jesus as apostles to show their new role as those who had been sent out (see study note on 3:14–15). This also helps avoid confusion with John the Baptist's disciples.
- The apostles reported the success of what they had done and taught.

## Mark 6:30–44

The disciples finish their mission (6:6–13, 30–34). Then the story of feeding the 5,000 follows (6:35–44; see also Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–15). The feeding of the 4,000 is different enough to show these were two separate events (see Mark 8:1–10).

## Mark 6:31–33

- Come with me: Jesus and the disciples likely traveled north along the western shore of the Sea of Galilee toward Bethsaida (Luke 9:10). As they moved, the crowds could still see them along the shore.
- many people: The large crowds show the success of the apostles' mission and the greatness of Jesus, whom the apostles represented.

## Mark 6:34

they were like sheep without a shepherd: God's people need guidance (Numbers 27:16–17; 1 Kings 22:17; 2 Chronicles 18:16; see Jeremiah 13:10; Ezekiel 34:23). In

Jewish writings, teaching God's word is like feeding sheep (for example, Ezekiel 34:1–24; 2 Baruch 77:13–15).

## Mark 6:35–36

The place where Jesus taught was remote (far from towns), but it still had farms and villages nearby where people could buy food.

## Mark 6:37

Jesus suggests that, just as the disciples were able to drive out demons and heal through his power (6:7, 13, 30), they should be able to feed the crowd. Their reply shows that they were thinking only about what they could do on their own. They did not take into account the power of Jesus (his ability to act with God's authority).

## Mark 6:41

The words taking, blessed, broke, and gave reflect the words Jesus spoke at the Last Supper (14:22–25). Both events imagine the final messianic feast where Christians will eat and drink with Jesus in the kingdom of God (14:25; Matthew 5:6; 22:1–10; see Revelation 2:7; 19:7–9; 22:1–2, 14, 17–19).

## Mark 6:42–44

This miracle makes Elisha's miracle of feeding 100 people with 20 loaves seem less impressive (2 Kings 4:42–44). We should ask ourselves, "Who is this?" (Mark 4:41). He is the Christ, the Son of God (1:1).

## Mark 6:45–46

The disciples went to Bethsaida, the hometown of Peter and Andrew (John 1:44). Meanwhile, Jesus dismissed the crowd and went away by himself to pray.

Jesus regularly prayed (Mark 1:35). He also urged his disciples to pray (see 14:38).

## Mark 6:45–52

This story shows the glory of Jesus (his divine power and greatness) to the disciples (6:48–50). It is also a rescue story, because Jesus comes to help them in danger (6:47–48, 51).

At the same time, it shows that the disciples did not understand what was happening (6:51–52).

## Mark 6:48

- About the fourth watch of the night: This was about three o'clock in the morning. This Roman way of telling time suggests that Mark wrote for Christians in Rome.
- Mark does not explain how Jesus saw his disciples struggling in the middle of the lake at night. It is not important to the story.
- Jesus went out to them, walking on the sea: It seems Jesus came to rescue them from the storm. But Mark says that Jesus intended to pass by them. Many have tried to explain this, but perhaps the best explanation is that to pass them by refers to a divine appearance. This is similar to events in Exodus and 1 Kings, where divine glory is shown. The disciples' fear supports this idea, as fear often accompanies divine appearances.
- Many have tried to explain the miracle of Jesus walking on water. But Mark, Matthew, and John saw it as a miracle without a natural explanation. If Jesus is truly the Son of God, there needs to be no other explanation.

## Mark 6:49–50

- The disciples were very afraid, and this reaction makes sense. People cannot walk on water, so they thought they were seeing a ghost.

As in many times when God appears (divine manifestations, when God shows himself), the Lord spoke words of comfort: "Take courage! It is I. Do not be afraid."
It was not a ghost but Jesus (their friend, Savior, and Lord).

- It is I : Jesus walking on the sea and calming the storm were miracles (acts of God's power). Because of this, Mark's first audience would have understood the words I am as more than a simple statement. They would have heard a connection to how God describes himself in the Old Testament (Exodus 3:14; Deuteronomy 32:39; Isaiah 41:4; 43:10–13). This suggests that Jesus shares in God's identity (he is divine).

## Mark 6:51

- When Jesus got into the boat, the storm stopped.
- utterly astounded: The disciples were filled with awe and reverence (deep respect and wonder) at the greatness of Jesus Christ, the Son of God (compare 2:12; 5:24; Matthew 14:33).

## Mark 6:52

The account ends with a comment about the disciples' lack of understanding. This was not because they lacked the opportunity to believe in Jesus. They had seen the miracle of the loaves and many other miracles.

Instead, their hearts were too hard (they were not open to understanding). This is usually a quality of those who oppose Jesus (for example, 3:5; see also 8:17, 21; 9:32).

Later, their hearts would be changed. They would come to understand these things (Luke 24:44–49; John 12:16; 13:7).

## Mark 6:53

Gennesaret was a fertile plain (good land for growing crops), about 5.6 kilometers long (3.5 miles) and 0.8 kilometers wide (0.5 miles). It lay between Tiberias and Capernaum on the northwest shore of the Sea of Galilee.

The disciples first planned to go to Bethsaida (6:45). One possibility is that strong winds (6:48) pushed the boat off course, and they landed at Gennesaret instead. Another possibility is that 6:45 describes the direction of travel (toward the northeast), not the exact destination.

## Mark 6:53–56

This short summary of the work Jesus did in Galilee shows how popular he was and how he healed many people.

## Mark 6:56

the fringe of His cloak: This refers to the tassels that Jewish men wore on the edges of their robes (see Numbers 15:38–39; Deuteronomy 22:12). Touching the fringe of His cloak brought healing to sick people (see also Mark 3:10; 5:28).

## Mark 7:1

Mark's audience already knows that the Pharisees and teachers of religious law were hostile to Jesus (see 2:16, 24; 3:6, 22).

## Mark 7:1–23

This account does not connect directly to what comes before it. It simply fits a general setting, such as "At one point in the ministry of Jesus."

After Mark sets the scene (7:1–4), he introduces the Pharisees' question (7:5). Then Jesus responds to the question (6–23).

The first part of the response focuses on two Old Testament passages (7:6–13). It also includes a two-part critique (strong criticism) of the Pharisees' traditions (7:6–8, 9–13).

In the second part, Jesus explains what truly defiles a person (what makes someone unclean before God; 7:14–23).

## Mark 7:2–4

Mark explains the Pharisees' practices of ritual cleansing (ceremonial washing for religious purity) for his non-Jewish (Gentile) audience.

The traditions of the elders were not yet written down at that time. The Pharisees believed these teachings had been given to Moses on Mount Sinai along with the written law.

These traditions were later written down around AD 200 in the Mishnah (a collection of Jewish teachings and laws). The Mishnah is one of the main sources for understanding ancient Judaism.

## Mark 7:5

Since the Pharisees believed that their oral traditions were given to Moses as part of God's divine revelation, they asked Jesus why his disciples did not keep them. After all, teachers were responsible for the behavior of their disciples (see 2:24).

## Mark 7:6–8

Jesus first responds by quoting Isaiah 29:13 (from the Greek version). This passage speaks about the problem of treating human ideas as if they were God's commands.

It describes well what was happening with the Pharisees. They had replaced God's law with their own traditions (human rules and teachings).

## Mark 7:9–13

Next, Jesus gives an example where the Pharisees' traditions went against God's law. Their traditions allowed them to avoid what God's law required.

## Mark 7:11–12

- But you say: The contrast with God's law is very strong. Their tradition went against God's command to honor parents by caring for their needs.
- 'Whatever you would have received from me is Corban' (that is, a gift devoted to God): This tradition taught that people could avoid helping their parents. They could promise to give their resources to God instead. In this way, they ignored and dishonored their parents, even when their parents were in need.

## Mark 7:13

- The result of such traditions was to cancel the word of God.
- in many such matters: This was not a unique instance (see, for example, Isaiah 1:10–20 and 58:1–14).

## Mark 7:14–23

The second argument of Jesus against the Pharisees was a proverb he told the crowd. Later, in a private setting, Jesus explained it to his disciples (7:17–23). It concerns moral distinctions about eating (rules about what is right or wrong to eat). Eating affects the system that processes food, but moral issues involve the heart. The heart is a metaphor for where a person makes moral decisions.

How a person eats (with ceremonially clean or unclean hands) or what a person eats (ceremonially clean or unclean food) only affects the system that processes food. So it does not impact the moral issues of the human soul or inner being. To help his later audience understand the meaning of this teaching, Mark adds this comment Thus all foods are clean.

In the early church, Peter and Paul helped make this meaning clear (see Acts 10:1–11:18; Romans 14:14; 1 Corinthians 8:8; Galatians 2:11–21).

## Mark 7:20–22

These verses list 13 things that truly make a person unclean (morally impure). These actions and wrong desires come from the heart (a person's inner thoughts and intentions).

## Mark 7:24

- The city of Tyre and its nearby areas are on the Mediterranean coast in modern Lebanon. Tyre was originally an island but became a peninsula when Alexander the Great built a half-mile ramp from the shore in 332 BC.

Tyre had one of the most important harbors on the eastern Mediterranean Sea. People from Tyre had previously come to hear Jesus and see his miracles (3:7–8). This explains how the woman from Tyre knew about him.

- There is much discussion about why Jesus left Galilee to visit this Gentile (non-Jewish) region. Mark does not explain the reason, so any suggestion is only a guess.

However, Mark's Gentile audience would have understood this journey as pointing ahead to the church's mission to the Gentile world. This mission later led to their own coming to faith (for more about how the church began in Rome, see Romans Book Introduction).

## Mark 7:24–30

The discussion of clean and unclean and of undefiled and defiled in 7:1–23 has prepared Mark's audience for the story of the Gentile woman's faith. Jews considered Gentiles to be defiled because they did not keep the regulations of the Torah (see Acts 10:1–11:18, especially 10:14–15; 11:2–3, 8–9).

## Mark 7:25–26

The woman was from Syrian Phoenicia and therefore a Gentile. The urgency and intensity of the woman's petition is seen in her falling at the feet of Jesus and begging.

## Mark 7:27–28

- Jesus responds to the woman in what might seem like a severe way. But their interaction shows that Jesus wanted to see her faith (compare Matthew 15:28).
- Jesus did not use the word first to exclude her as a Gentile (non-Jew) from God's grace (kindness and favor). Instead, it showed that his mission was directed first to the Jews (Acts 13:46; Romans 1:16).

The woman replied with humility and faith. She acknowledged the priority of the Jewish people but argued that there was more than enough food for the dogs as well.
Jewish writings often referred to Gentiles as dogs. Dogs were seen as dirty scavengers rather than family pets (see also study note on Revelation 22:15).
The woman's persistence and acknowledgment of Jesus as Lord were rewarded.

## Mark 7:29–30

For similar healings from a distance, see Matthew 8:5–13, Luke 7:1–10, and John 4:46–54.

## Mark 7:31–37

- This miracle is very similar in order and wording to the healing of the blind man in 8:22–26. Healing miracles in the Gospels often follow a similar pattern. As these stories were told and retold, their form and wording likely became more consistent.
- This miracle also includes a change of location. Some think the next miracle happened in a Gentile area such as Sidon or the Decapolis. However, it is more likely that it took place after Jesus returned to the Sea of Galilee. The next event clearly happens there (8:10), with no change in location mentioned.

## Mark 7:33

- The healing was done in private (7:33; see 5:40–43; 8:23). This likely helped prevent people from spreading strong excitement about Jesus as the Messiah (God's chosen king; see 3:11–12; compare John 6:15).
- Jesus also used saliva in another healing (Mark 8:23), when he put it on a man's eyes to heal his blindness. The use of saliva for healing was common in the ancient world. People believed it could help heal certain conditions.

## Mark 7:34

- And looking up to heaven, He sighed deeply: Since Jesus was looking up to heaven when he sighed, his sigh is probably best understood as a prayerful gesture.
- Ephphatha is an Aramaic word that Mark translates for his audience (see also 3:17; 5:41; 14:36; 15:34). These are not magical words. Mark is simply sharing some of the original words Jesus spoke.

Matthew and Luke do not seem to have attributed any special importance to the Aramaic words of Jesus, since they did not include them in their Gospels.

## Mark 7:36–37

Even though Jesus tried to avoid attention, his greatness could not be hidden. His character, his teaching, and his power to heal filled people with awe (deep wonder and respect).

## Mark 8:1–3

The last mention of a large crowd was during the feeding of the 5,000 (6:34). Jesus showed compassion in 6:34 because the people were "like sheep without a shepherd."

These stories show the concern Jesus has for the whole person. Here, he especially focuses on their hunger. They were in the wilderness and had no food (8:1,4). They had been with Jesus for three days without food and had traveled a long way (8:2). They needed to eat before going home (8:3).

## Mark 8:1–10

The stories about feeding the 4,000 and the 5,000 are similar. All four Gospels report the earlier feeding of the 5,000 (6:35–44; Matthew 14:13–21; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–15). Only Mark and Matthew also record the feeding of the 4,000 as a separate miracle (Matthew 15:32–39; Mark 8:19–21; Matthew 16:9–10). The details of the events are different.

## Mark 8:4

The disciples' question shows their lack of understanding. They knew God provided manna in the wilderness during the time of Moses (Exodus 16). They were now with someone much greater than Moses (see Mark 9:5–7). They had recently seen him feed more people in a similar situation (6:30–44).

But they still did not understand (compare 6:52). Even so, Jesus used them to provide physical and spiritual food to the hungry (8:6–8). What they could not do alone, the powerful Son of God did through them.

## Mark 8:5

Seven: Many people have tried to find symbolic meaning in the numbers in the two feeding miracles. However, there is no agreement among these interpretations. The mention of "a few fish" in this story also suggests that the numbers are not symbolic.

None of the Gospel writers explain any special meaning for these numbers. This should caution us not to assign meaning to them.

As with the feeding of the five thousand, the numbers mainly serve to highlight the greatness of the miracle and of Jesus.

## Mark 8:6–7

took ... gave thanks ... distributed: These terms describe the actions of Jesus during this event. These same actions appear later the Last Supper (compare 14:22–25).

## Mark 8:8

They ate as much as they wanted. Having plenty of food shows the greatness of God's kingdom and the one who brought it.

## Mark 8:10–13

- Like the earlier miracle where Jesus fed 5,000 people (6:30–44), after feeding 4,000 people, Jesus traveled across the Sea of Galilee by boat (compare 6:45). When he arrived, the Pharisees came to argue with him. They demanded that Jesus show them a miracle as proof (compare 7:1–23).
- We do not know where Dalmanutha was located. Matthew 15:39 uses the name Magadan instead of Dalmanutha when describing this place.

## Mark 8:11

The Pharisees continued to oppose Jesus (2:16–18, 24; 3:6; 7:1–5; 10:2; 12:13, 15). Their hostility did not stop.

Sometimes, asking for a sign is acceptable (Judges 6:36–40; 2 Kings 20:8–11; Isaiah 7:10–12; see also John 2:18–19). But in this case, their request was not sincere. It was a stubborn test of God (they were trying to challenge or trap him).

They were not asking for the kinds of signs Jesus had already done, such as healings, driving out demons (evil spirits), raising the dead, or controlling nature. Many of these had already happened, and people widely knew about them (Mark 1:32–34, 45; 3:7–12; 6:53–56). Even the Pharisees knew about them (3:22).

Instead, they wanted a sign from heaven (that is, a direct sign from God) to prove once for all that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen king). But no sign would have convinced them.

For those who were open to the truth, the miracles Jesus had already done were clear signs that he is the Messiah, the Son of God (Luke 7:22). But for those who were not open, no sign would lead them to believe (Mark 4:11–12; compare Luke 6:19–31).

## Mark 8:12

- Truly I tell you: This response is very strong. It is like an oath (a serious promise) and means something like, "[May God judge me] if I give this generation any such sign." Such statements show firm and unchanging commitment (see Genesis 14:22–23; Numbers 32:10–11; Ruth 1:17; 1 Samuel 3:17; 20:13; 2 Samuel 3:35; 19:13).
- Elsewhere, Jesus describes this generation as "adulterous and sinful" in Mark 8:38 and "unbelieving" in 9:19.

## Mark 8:14

The mention of having only one loaf of bread reminds Mark's audience of earlier times when the disciples did not have enough food. On those occasions, Jesus miraculously provided enough bread to feed thousands of people.

## Mark 8:14–21

This story of the journey across the Sea of Galilee reflects on the greatness of Jesus, shown in the two feeding miracles. It also emphasizes the disciples' lack of understanding.

They do not see, hear, or understand because their hearts are hardened (not open to learning; see 4:9–20; 6:52).

## Mark 8:15

Matthew says that the leaven of the Pharisees refers to their false teaching (Matthew 16:12). It might also refer to their unbelief and stubbornness (Mark 8:10–13).

The reference to Herod could suggest he was unwilling to accept what he knew to be true (6:14, 16, 20).

## Mark 8:16

The disciples completely missed the meaning of the warning given by Jesus (8:15). They forgot that, because Jesus was with them, their lack of bread did not matter.

## Mark 8:17–20

Jesus asked eight questions that rebuked the disciples. They, of all people, should have been aware of the miraculous power of the Son of God. Although the disciples still remembered the feeding miracles, they did not apply their meaning to the situation they were facing.

## Mark 8:19–20

The questions of Jesus clearly recalled the feeding miracles (6:30–44; 8:1–10). He asked the disciples how many baskets of leftovers they had gathered after each event. By asking these questions, Jesus reminded them of what had already happened.

## Mark 8:21

Do you still not understand?: This question suggests there will be a future time when they will truly understand. Mark's audience knew that the resurrection of Jesus would help the disciples understand the identity and power of Jesus (see, for example, Acts 4:23–31).

## Mark 8:22–26

- Earlier, Jesus and the disciples tried to go to Bethsaida but did not succeed (6:45). Here, they arrive, and Jesus heals a blind man. Only Mark describes this two-part healing. It might connect to how the disciples came to a new spiritual understanding in the next story (8:27–38).
- John 1:44 says Bethsaida is the home of Peter, Andrew, James, and John (see also John 12:21). This small fishing village was officially part of Gaulanitis. But people usually considered it part of Galilee (John 12:21). It was relocated and given status as a city by Philip the Tetrarch (Josephus, Antiquities 18.2.1).

## Mark 8:23

He spit on the man's eyes (see 7:33; compare with John 9:6–7): We do not know exactly what eye problem the man had. Any attempt to identify it is only a guess and can distract from the miracle.

## Mark 8:24–25

The healing was not immediate. At first, the man saw imperfectly. After Jesus touched him a second time, he fully healed the man.

Who is this man who calms the sea and heals the blind? Peter reveals this in the next account. He is the Christ (8:29).

## Mark 8:26

The story ends with Jesus telling the healed man to keep the event a secret (see 3:11–12).

## Mark 8:27–28

- Philip the Tetrarch (a regional ruler) was the son of Herod the Great. Philip built Caesarea Philippi on the slopes of Mount Hermon, about 40 kilometers (25 miles) north of the Sea of Galilee. The more famous Caesarea on the coast was built by his father.
- Who do people say I am?: As a good teacher, Jesus asked this question to understand what his disciples thought. Their answer is similar to 6:14–16.
- John the Baptist: See study note on 6:14.
- one of the prophets: Many people saw Jesus as a prophet (a person who speaks for God; see 6:4; 14:65; Luke 7:16, 39; 13:33; 24:19).

## Mark 8:27–38

Peter's declaration that Jesus is the Christ (the Messiah, God's chosen king) and the first prediction of his death mark a turning point in the Gospel of Mark. This begins a new stage in his ministry. The question, "Who is this?" asked by the disciples in 4:41, is now answered by Peter.

## Mark 8:27–9.1

This section is the first cycle (a repeated pattern) that includes three parts:

- Jesus predicts his suffering (8:31),
- the disciples respond with misunderstanding (8:32–33), and
- Jesus teaches about discipleship (what it means to follow him; 8:34–9:1).

Compare with 9:30–10:31.

## Mark 8:29–30

Who do you say I am?: In the Greek text, the word you is emphatic. Peter spoke for the group, saying, You are the Christ. Peter's confession was correct, as the command not to tell anyone about him shows (see 3:11–12; see also 1:1; 14:61–62; Matthew 16:17).

## Mark 8:31

- God thought it necessary for Jesus to suffer (see also 9:11; 13:7, 10). The elders, leading priests, and teachers of religious law caused his suffering. But it was ultimately God's will (see 10:33; 11:18, 27; 14:1, 43, 53).
- The death of Jesus would not be the end. Three days later, he would rise from the dead.
- after three days: This has the same meaning as "on the third day" and "will be three days and three nights" (Matthew 16:21; Luke 9:22; Matthew 12:40).

## Mark 8:31–38

Then He began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders, chief priests, and scribes, and that He must be killed and after three days rise again: Jesus now clearly predicted what he had previously revealed in a hidden way (2:19–20). In response, Peter objected, so Jesus taught him and the other disciples the nature of his mission and what it really means to follow him.

## Mark 8:32

Peter understood what Jesus had said, but he did not accept it. Peter shared the popular idea that the Messiah was to be a victorious national ruler, so he thought it made no sense for Jesus to talk of suffering and death.

## Mark 8:33

- Jesus looked at his disciples before he corrected Peter in public. He wanted them to understand Peter's mistake.
- Get behind Me, Satan!: Jesus does not mean that a demon possessed Peter. Peter spoke from a human perspective, not God's. So without knowing it, he spoke for Satan, "the god of this age" (2 Corinthians 4:4). He repeated Satan's temptation (compare Matthew 4:8–10).

## Mark 8:34–38

- Jesus invites his disciples and the crowd to understand what following him will cost them.
- must deny himself: This means letting Jesus decide your goals and purposes in life. Taking up your cross

is a metaphor (compare Luke 9:23). It means being faithful to Jesus, even to the point of death if necessary. Following the teachings and example of Jesus requires continual commitment.

### Mark 8:35

If a person tries to save his life by rejecting Jesus, that person will lose it in the next world. But if you give your life to Jesus and the spread of the gospel, you will save it forever.

### Mark 8:36–37

The implied answer to the rhetorical question Jesus asks is that possessing the entire world has no value if you give up eternal life. "He is no fool who gives what he cannot keep to gain that which he cannot lose" (Jim Elliot). You need your soul to enjoy the benefits of the world to come. When you forfeit your life or soul, there is nothing you can give to purchase it back.

### Mark 8:38

When Jesus, as the Son of Man, returns in glory to judge the world, he will be ashamed of those who were ashamed to be identified with him and his message (compare Matthew 7:21–23; 10:32–33; Luke 12:8–9; 2 Timothy 2:12).

### Mark 9:1

Truly I tell you: This introductory phrase shows that this promise is important, but people debate what the promise means. It might mean that some disciples will:

- witness the resurrection of Jesus from the dead (chapter 16);
- experience the coming of the Holy Spirit upon the church (Acts 2);
- witness the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70; or
- witness the transfiguration of Jesus as a preview of God's coming kingdom.

Mark places this promise right before the transfiguration story (Mark 9:2–8). This suggests he likely considered the transfiguration as its fulfillment (see 2 Peter 1:16–18).

### Mark 9:2–8

- This story is connected to 8:27–9:1 both chronologically (After six days) and thematically (9:7).
- The presence of Peter, James, and John might be the fulfillment of "some standing here" in 9:1 (see also 5:37; 13:3; 14:33). Some interpreters believe that the Son of God's glory before he became human (his pre-incarnate glory) shone through his human nature for a moment at the transfiguration (John 1:14; 17:5). It is more likely that this event was an early glimpse of the Son of Man's future glory (see Matthew 16:28; 2 Peter 1:16–18; compare Exodus 34:28–35; 2 Corinthians 3:7–18).

### Mark 9:4

The appearance of Elijah and Moses might indicate the fulfillment of the law and the prophets in Jesus (see Matthew 5:17; compare Malachi 4:4–5).

### Mark 9:5–6

The idea to put up three shelters as memorials treats Moses, Elijah, and Jesus as equals (see Leviticus 23:33–43; Numbers 29:12–34). But this idea ignored Peter's earlier confession that Jesus is the Messiah (Mark 8:29). It also ignored that only Jesus had been transfigured (his appearance changed and showed his glory, 9:2–3).

### Mark 9:7

- a cloud: Compare Exodus 40:34–35.
- The voice from the cloud gave a strong correction to Peter's suggestion: This is My beloved Son. He is not equal to Moses and Elijah. God's voice also confirmed what Peter had said earlier (Mark 8:29). At the same time, it gently corrected Peter for rejecting the prediction Jesus made about his suffering (8:32). God told Peter and the other disciples to listen to Jesus.

### Mark 9:8

Only Jesus remained, not Moses or Elijah. Jesus was clearly superior to Elijah and Moses.

### Mark 9:9

Secrecy would no longer be needed after the Son of Man had risen from the dead. At that point, people would understand that Jesus the Messiah (God's chosen king) did not come as a political or military leader. Because of this, his message could be announced openly to everyone (see Acts 2:36; 3:6).

### Mark 9:10

The three disciples only understood what Jesus meant by rise from the dead after it happened.

### Mark 9:11

The disciples wanted to understand the prophecy that Elijah must come first before the Messiah (see Malachi 4:5–6). They wondered how this prophecy fit with the

teachings of Jesus about God's kingdom and his own death, resurrection, and second coming (Mark 8:31, 38; 9:9).

### Mark 9:12

The teachers of the law were correct that Elijah must come before the completion of God's kingdom (the time when God fully establishes his rule). But Scripture also says that the Son of Man must suffer greatly (for example, Psalm 22; Isaiah 52:13–53:12).

### Mark 9:13

The teachers of the law made a mistake by not realizing that Elijah had already come (see Matthew 17:11–13; compare Malachi 4:5–6). Because of this, they did not recognize that the kingdom of God had already arrived. They also failed to realize that the Messiah's suffering and death, which were predicted in Scripture, were about to take place.

### Mark 9:14

Jesus and the three disciples (Peter, James, and John) returned to the other disciples, the crowd, and the teachers of the law. This event is similar to when Moses came down from Mount Sinai to join the people of Israel (Exodus 34:29–35).

### Mark 9:14–29

This is the fourth and final time Jesus drives out demons in Mark's Gospel (1:21–28; 5:1–20; 7:24–30). The disciples could not drive out the demon, so Jesus performed the exorcism. This emphasizes the need for faith (see 2:5; 5:34; 10:52). This is another example of the great healing ability of Jesus and of the failure of the disciples (8:32–33; 9:5–7).

### Mark 9:15

Some have suggested that, just as Moses reflected God's glory after he came down from the mountain, Jesus still showed the glory of his transfiguration. This may explain why the crowd reacted with awe. It is also possible that the crowd responded with awe simply because Jesus returned after being away.

### Mark 9:18

These symptoms are often associated with epilepsy (a medical condition that can cause seizures; see Matthew 17:15). But Mark emphasizes that the cause of the child's problem was a demon (Mark 9:17–18, 25–26, 28). The disciples' failure to heal the child emphasizes the effect of the power of Jesus (9:25–26).

### Mark 9:19

- Jesus replied: Jesus might have been speaking to the disciples, the father, the crowd, or everyone present (9:22–24).
- How long?: Their lack of faith was stubborn and would not stop (compare 3:5; 6:52; 8:17; 10:5).

### Mark 9:20

The demon did not speak (compare 1:24; 5:7, 9–10; see also 1:34; 3:11–12). Instead, it acted violently, just as the father had described (9:18).

### Mark 9:21–22

- The demon's activity had been taking place since he was a little boy, and the demon had tried to kill the child in various ways.
- If You can: The father's request shows that his faith had become weak (9:18).

### Mark 9:23

Jesus urged the man to trust in the power of God. Anything is possible if a person believes (see 11:22–24). But a lack of faith can limit how people receive God's saving work (see 6:5).

### Mark 9:24

In desperation, the father cried out that he believed, though weakly.

### Mark 9:25

- The crowd was approaching, so Jesus quickly drove out the demon.
- The I in the command to the demon is emphatic and highlights Jesus's authority and power.
- never enter him again: Sometimes driving out demons did not stop them from coming back (see Matthew 12:43–45; Luke 11:24–26).

### Mark 9:26–27

The demon reacted with great force. This showed how powerful the demon was and how much greater Jesus was (compare 1:25–26; 5:15).

### Mark 9:28–29

The story ends in an unexpected way. It emphasizes the importance of prayer more than the importance of faith (compare 11:22–24).

### Mark 9:30–10.31

This section is the second cycle (see study note on 8:27–9:1) containing:

- a prediction about the suffering of Jesus (9:30–32),
- an error by the disciples (9:33–34), and
- teaching about discipleship (9:35–10:31).

### Mark 9:31

- Jesus continued to seek privacy to teach the disciples about his future suffering (see 7:24).
- The Son of Man will be delivered: See 14:10–11, 41–45.

### Mark 9:32

The disciples were still unable to accept the teaching of Jesus concerning his death or to recognize how it fit into God's plan.

### Mark 9:33–34

- Capernaum was where Jesus lived in Galilee (1:21; 2:1).
- The disciples of Jesus did not answer his question because they knew he would not approve of their discussion.
- arguing about which of them was the greatest: This issue would come up again in 10:35–37.

### Mark 9:33–50

The disciples did not understand the prediction Jesus made about his suffering. Because of this, they could not see what it meant for their own lives.

### Mark 9:35

Sitting down: Jesus sat down and took the role of a teacher (see 4:1–2; 12:41; Matthew 5:1; Luke 4:20; 5:3).

True greatness in the kingdom of God means serving others, not ruling over them. Jesus showed this by his own example (Mark 10:45).

### Mark 9:36–37

In the time of Jesus, people did not view children as especially innocent or pure. Instead, they saw them as weak and of low status. Jesus said that people should receive a child in his name (that is, as his representative).

Welcoming a child shows humility. It means choosing a low place and serving others (9:35; see also 10:13–16). Other teachings of Jesus show that how people receive or reject his followers is the same as how they receive or reject him (Matthew 10:40; 25:31–46; Luke 10:16; John 13:20).

### Mark 9:38–41

- An unknown person was driving out demons in the name of Jesus, even though he was not one of the twelve disciples (9:38–40). John objected, but Jesus corrected him.
- we tried to stop him: Compare 10:35–43; Luke 9:51–55.
- The success of the unknown person who drove out demons contrasts with the disciples' failure in the previous story (Mark 9:14–29).

### Mark 9:40

The negative parallel to this proverb is found in Luke 11:23. These two proverbs should be understood as complementary, not contradictory, for Luke includes them both (Luke 9:50; 11:23). The person who drove out demons in the name of Jesus was not against Jesus, but for him.

### Mark 9:42–50

If anyone causes ... sin: The repeated warning about causing sin connects these verses (9:42–43, 45, 47). Jesus did not mean that people should take these words literally. Cutting off a body part would not stop sin (see Matthew 15:10–20). Instead, Jesus warns that no sin is worth the punishment of hell. It is better to repent (turn away from sin), even when repentance is very painful, than to face hell.

### Mark 9:43

hell: The Greek word Gehenna refers to the Valley of Hinnom, located southwest of Jerusalem. It became a picture of hell because some Israelites had sacrificed their children there to false gods (Jeremiah 32:35).

### Mark 9:43–48

Some Bible versions include verses 44 and 46 here, but these two verses are absent from most of the earliest and best manuscripts. These two verses were almost certainly copied from 9:48 and were not in the original text of Mark.

### Mark 9:48

never dies ... never quenched: These phrases emphasize the eternal nature of hell (see 9:43). Hell is a place of everlasting fire, decay, and corruption, where worms endlessly consume everything. This acts as a strong warning for people to repent to avoid hell's punishment.

### Mark 9:49–50

- salted with fire: The fire of testing has a purifying effect, like salt (see also 1 Peter 1:7; 4:12; Revelation 3:18). Salt also refers to Christian character. Genuine

Christian character will have a genuinely purifying influence.
- but if the salt loses its saltiness: Salt from the Dead Sea often contained gypsum, a soft mineral. Because of this, it could look like good salt but still be useless. It did not taste salty, and people could not easily throw it away because it was not good for soil or other uses.

## Mark 10:1–2

The Pharisees asked Jesus about divorce because they wanted to trap him. Divorce was already a debated issue among the Jews (see 2:16, 18, 24; 7:5; 8:11; 12:13). John the Baptist was executed by order of Herod Antipas. John had publicly said that Herod's marriage to Herodias was unlawful because she had been his brother's wife (6:18–19). The Jewish historian Josephus says that John was killed near this area, east of the Jordan River, at Herod Antipas's fortress called Machaerus (see 6:28; Josephus, Antiquities 18.5.2).

If Jesus agreed with John, the Pharisees could accuse him before Herod. But if Jesus said divorce was lawful, he would seem to disagree with a prophet.

## Mark 10:3

Jesus answered the trick question of the Pharisees with a counter-question. Instead of replying directly, he asked them a question in return (see Matthew 22:20).

## Mark 10:4

The Pharisees quoted what Moses permitted. There was much debate among rabbis as to what constituted the "some indecency" that made divorce permissible (see Deuteronomy 24:1). Rabbi Shammai allowed divorce only on the basis of sexual immorality. Rabbi Hillel permitted divorce even if a woman burned her husband's dinner or was less attractive than someone else (Mishnah Gittin 9:10).

## Mark 10:5–9

God allowed divorce because people's hearts were hard, meaning they would not obey God. But the passages that Jesus quotes from the law of Moses show God's true plan for marriage (Genesis 1:27; 2:23–24; see also Malachi 2:16). These passages show that God values marriage. In marriage, a man and woman form a new union, and the two become one. People should not go against God's will by separating what God has joined together.

## Mark 10:10

Jesus often explained his teaching to his disciples in the privacy of a house (see 7:17; 9:28, 33).

## Mark 10:11–12

Whoever divorces ... and marries another ... commits adultery: The parallel in Luke 16:18 agrees with Mark and mentions no exceptions to this prohibition of divorce. But Matthew's passage allows an exception when one spouse commits adultery (Matthew 19:9; see also 5:32). The apostle Paul also allows an exception if an unbelieving spouse leaves the marriage (1 Corinthians 7:15).

Mark's account focuses on the main teachings about marriage and divorce:

- God hates divorce (Malachi 2:16),
- marriage is meant to last for life, and
- divorce goes against God's purpose for marriage.

## Mark 10:13

- We cannot determine the children's ages from this passage. The Greek word paidia can refer to a wide range of ages, from a twelve-year-old child to an eight-day-old infant (5:41–42; Genesis 17:12, Greek version).
- The disciples rebuked those who brought them: See study note on Luke 18:15–17.

## Mark 10:13–16

The love and concern Jesus has for children can already be seen in 5:41–43, 9:36–37, and 42. Jesus uses this event to teach that the kingdom of God belongs to those who are like children.

## Mark 10:14–15

Mark does not explain which qualities of children make them fit for the kingdom of God. Matthew 18:4–5 suggests that these qualities include humility and a simple trust in receiving what is given.

## Mark 10:17

The rich man (10:22) was a young ruler (Matthew 19:20; Luke 18:18). He showed respect toward Jesus by kneeling and calling him Good Teacher.

Teacher is a common title for Jesus in Mark (see Mark 4:38; 5:35; 9:17, 38; 10:20, 35; 12:14, 19, 32; 13:1; 14:14). The addition of good is unique.

## Mark 10:17–31

The story of the rich man continues the themes of discipleship that began in 9:33 and the requirements for entering the kingdom of God (10:13–16). The rich man's attitude is very different from the humble, childlike faith needed to enter the kingdom of God.

## Mark 10:18

Jesus replied. "No one is good except God alone.": This response has troubled interpreters for centuries. Jesus was likely correcting the man's casual use of the word good for a human being. Perfect goodness belongs to God alone.

Jesus was not denying his own goodness. Instead, he wanted to direct the man's attention to God. The rich man wanted to enter the kingdom of God, and Jesus contrasted God's goodness with the man's own sinfulness.

## Mark 10:19

This reply may sound strange to Christians who know Paul's teaching on this subject (for example, Romans 3:20; Galatians 2:16). In naming five of the Ten Commandments, Jesus was not implying that the man could earn eternal life by keeping them. Instead, he was telling him what God's standards are and letting the man examine his own life.

To truly love God with all our heart, soul, mind, and strength, and to love our neighbor as ourselves (Mark 12:30–31), we must:

- trust in God's grace,
- receive the sacrificial death of Jesus for us (Mark 10:45; Mark 14:24), and
- obey his commands (John 15:10; 1 John 2:4; 1 John 3:22).

## Mark 10:20

The man's reply showed a lack of understanding about what it really means to keep these commands (see Matthew 5:21–48), but it was not arrogant. The absence of any criticism supports this (compare Mark 12:13–17; Matthew 23:1–36).

## Mark 10:21

- Instead of having an extended discussion about what it means to truly keep the commandments, Jesus focused on the specific issue that revealed this man's problem. He still lacked one thing: He loved riches more than he loved God, thus breaking the first and most important commandment (12:29–30; Exodus 20:3; Deuteronomy 6:5).

Entering the kingdom of God requires repentance (Mark 1:15; 6:12). Jesus helped this man to understand exactly what repentance meant for him. He did not need, as he might have thought, to attain a higher level of personal righteousness. He needed to enter God's kingdom through repentance and deep love for God to gain eternal life. He must deny himself and love God first by giving away his money (8:34).
For other commands with a negative (sell everything) and a positive (follow Me) element, see 1:15, 18, 20; 10:28; see also Acts 2:38; 20:21.

- The command Jesus gave to the rich man was not a strict rule for everyone entering the kingdom of God, but was specific to his situation. It teaches that nothing should come before God. Repentance requires removing anything we place above God (Mark 1:15; 6:12).

## Mark 10:22

Mark records the rich man's tragic choice. The man departed, still possessing his earthly riches (Matthew 6:19) but lacking eternal treasure (13:44–46). His expression was saddened and in sorrow. This revealed he knew his awful choice brought him no joy.

## Mark 10:23–27

Jesus surprised the disciples by challenging the common belief that wealth was a sign of God's favor.

## Mark 10:24

When the disciples were amazed, Jesus spoke to them with care and called them children.

## Mark 10:25

- Jesus strongly warned that riches can keep people from entering the kingdom of God. In Palestine, the camel was the largest animal, and the eye of a needle was the smallest opening. Jesus used this picture to show how difficult it is for rich people to follow him.

Even so, some rich people did follow Jesus. Still, more of the followers of Jesus came from the poor than from the rich.

- Some people say that the eye of the needle was a small gate in Jerusalem's wall. But this explanation is not convincing. There is no evidence that such a gate ever existed. It also ignores how Jesus commonly used hyperbole (intentional exaggeration for emphasis) in his teaching (see also Matthew 7:3–5; 23:24).

## Mark 10:26

They were even more astonished: Many people believed that wealth was a sign of God's blessing and that rich people could use their money to do good deeds. Because of this, people often assumed that the rich had a better chance of entering the kingdom of God. So the disciples' question was understandable. But God's view was very different from the common thinking of their time.

## Mark 10:27

People usually interpret this verse in one of two ways:

1. Although salvation by one's own effort is impossible, by God's grace people can be saved through faith (see Ephesians 2:8–10).
2. God can give an unusual grace that enables people to overcome their sinful love of riches and believe.

Mark does not explain his understanding.

## Mark 10:28

The disciples had done what Jesus told the rich man to do. They had given up everything to follow Jesus (1:16–20; 8:34–38).

## Mark 10:29–30

- Jesus assured his disciples that they would receive whatever they had given up for him many times over. This includes a new family in Christ (brothers and sisters and mothers and children) and Christian hospitality (houses).
- a hundredfold: The benefits of following Jesus are far greater than any loss. And in the world to come they will inherit the eternal life that the rich man desired but did not receive.

## Mark 10:31

But many who are first: The account ends with a proverb, contrasting the way that God understands life and how people generally understand it (for similar sayings, see Matthew 20:16; Luke 13:30). For those with eyes to see and ears to hear (Mark 4:9–12; 8:18), the kingdom of God has already come. The overturning of this world's values has begun.

## Mark 10:32–34

The disciples' amazement and the people's fear made them worried about what would happen next. The religious leaders in Jerusalem were already hostile toward Jesus (see 3:22–30; 7:1–13).

Jesus took the disciples aside again and described the coming events in more detail than before (see also 8:31; 9:31). He knew what was about to happen. What awaited him in Jerusalem was not a tragedy or an accident, but part of God's plan (see 8:31–33; Acts 4:27–28). As the Son of God, Jesus understood that he would die a unique death as the Savior of the world.

## Mark 10:33

- The leading priests and the teachers of the law were the human means by which God's plan was carried out through their hatred of Jesus.
- The Jewish leaders did not have authority to carry out capital punishment (the death penalty) under Roman rule (John 18:31). So they handed Jesus over to the Romans, who carried out the execution.

## Mark 10:35–45

After Jesus predicts his suffering for the third time (10:32–33), the disciples fail again (see 8:31–33; 9:31–34). The first part of the account involves the foolish request of James and John (10:35–37). Jesus responds to them (10:38–40). Then Jesus explains to the other disciples what greatness and leadership in the kingdom of God mean (10:41–44).

Jesus gave the greatest example of humble service(10:45). This example concludes the account.

## Mark 10:37

The brothers' request shows that James and John knew Jesus was the Christ (see 8:29; 9:2–8). However, they completely misunderstood what it meant to be a leader in God's kingdom (10:41–45).

## Mark 10:38

- You do not know what you are asking: To share in his glory, they must also share in his suffering as servants.
- drink the cup: Drinking from a cup often represents suffering and death (Psalm 75:8; Isaiah 51:17, 22; Jeremiah 25:15; 49:12; Lamentations 4:21; see also Mark 14:24, 36).
- The baptism of suffering points back to the full commitment Jesus showed to God's calling at his baptism. It also points to the believer's union with Jesus in his death, burial, and resurrection through baptism (Romans 6:3–5; Colossians 2:12).

## Mark 10:39

James and John truly experienced suffering for Jesus. James died for his faith (Acts 12:1–5). John died an old

man, having experienced persecution (Tertullian, The Soul 50; Jerome, Commentary on Galatians 6, 10).

Yet the death of James and John was not the same the death of Jesus. No believer can die the death of Jesus as a sacrifice for the world's sins (Mark 10:45) or experience the unique suffering he experienced on the cross (15:34).

## Mark 10:40

Jesus did not grant their request. These places belong to those for whom God the Father has prepared them (see also 13:32).

## Mark 10:41

the ten ... became indignant: Perhaps they wanted the special places requested by James and John for themselves. All of the disciples needed a new understanding of what leadership in God's kingdom means (10:42–45).

## Mark 10:42–44

the rulers of the Gentiles: The unbelieving world (the rulers in this world) thinks that leadership means dominating others. Just as the role of Jesus as Messiah and Son of God meant suffering and death (8:31; 9:31; 10:32–34, 45), being his follower involves serving others, not ruling over them (9:35; John 10:11).

## Mark 10:45

- Jesus offered his own example to demonstrate what leadership in God's kingdom means.
- Jesus understands his death as a ransom. A ransom was a payment made to free a slave or captive.
- The phrase for many likely refers to Isaiah 53:12, where many means all (compare Romans 5:15, 18–20). The death of Jesus was for all humanity. Later, Jesus would speak of his blood as being "poured out for many" (Mark 14:24).

## Mark 10:46

- they came to Jericho: The journey Jesus began in 10:1 was nearing its end. Jericho was the last major city in the Jordan River Valley before Jerusalem. It may be the oldest continuously occupied city in the world.

In the time of Jesus, it was no longer located on the much smaller site of Old Testament times (Tell es-Sultan). It had been moved and become much larger. The road from Jericho to Jerusalem was steep, with an elevation change of about 1,000 meters (3,000 feet).

- The large crowd following Jesus might have been fellow travelers going to Jerusalem for Passover. But the crowd also showed how popular and influential Jesus had become.
- A blind beggar ... was sitting beside the road: This was a good place to collect gifts of money from religious travelers going to Jerusalem.

## Mark 10:46–52

The healing of blind Bartimaeus is the last healing miracle in the Gospel of Mark. This event and the healing of the blind man in 8:22–26 frame this section (see Mark Book Introduction, "Literary Features").

It also connects this story to the entry of Jesus into Jerusalem as Israel's Messiah (the Christ, God's chosen king) in 11:1–11. Bartimaeus' cry for help (Jesus, Son of David) prepares Mark's audience for the confession of the people upon the arrival of Jesus in Jerusalem (11:10).

## Mark 10:47–48

- When he heard: News of Jesus had reached Jericho, just as it had spread into Gentile regions (3:8).
- Jesus, Son of David: Mark does not explain how Bartimaeus knew that Jesus was a descendant of David. He may have believed that Jesus was the Messiah. However, Bartimaeus did not connect this title with political or military hopes, as many people in that time did.

Instead, he understood that Jesus cared for the poor, disabled, lame, and blind. So he asked Jesus for mercy and healing (10:51). This matched how Jesus understood his own mission (compare Luke 4:18–19).

## Mark 10:50

Bartimaeus probably threw off his coat because he was so happy. It could also be a symbolic act of leaving his old life or leaving all to follow Jesus.

## Mark 10:51

"let me see again.": Bartimaeus's request showed his faith. Without faith, he might have just asked for charity. The stories he heard about Jesus encouraged him to cry out for the miracle of sight.

## Mark 10:52

Christ rewarded the man's faith and healed him (literally saved; see 5:23, 28, 34; 6:56; Matthew 9:22; Luke 8:48). The healing was performed without touch, in contrast to the healing of the blind man in Mark 8:22–26. Bartimaeus followed Jesus (see also 1:18; 2:14–15;

6:1; 8:34; 10:21, 28, 32) down the road (compare 1:2–3; 10:32).

## Mark 11:1

- Jerusalem was where Jesus intended to go. During the week before his crucifixion, Jesus apparently stayed in Bethany with his disciples (11:11–12; 14:3–9).
- The Mount of Olives is often associated with the site of the final judgment (Zechariah 14:4) and the place where the Messiah will appear (Ezekiel 11:23; 43:1–5; see also Josephus, Antiquities 20.8.6).
- As he did at other times, Jesus sent two of them (see Mark 6:7).

## Mark 11:1–13.37

- This section focuses on the relationship between Jesus and the temple in Jerusalem. In Mark's Gospel, all the events and teachings connected with Jerusalem are gathered in 11:1–16:8.
- The section ends with the second long teaching discourse of Jesus (13:1–37) (see 4:1–34). In this discourse, Jesus speaks about the destruction of the temple and the coming of the Son of Man. This teaching is the high point of many warnings in 11:1–13:37 about God's coming judgment on Jerusalem and the temple (see especially 11:12–25 and 12:1–12).

## Mark 11:2–3

There have already been numerous examples of the supernatural knowledge of Jesus (2:8; 3:5; 5:30, 32; 8:17, 31). But people's acceptance of the reply that the Lord needs it (11:3, 6) suggests that Jesus had prearranged it (compare 14:13–16). Jesus had intentionally planned to enter Jerusalem in fulfillment of Zechariah 9:9.

## Mark 11:3

The Lord needs it and will return it shortly: Earlier in Mark's Gospel, the title Lord is used for Jesus (1:3; 2:28; 5:19; see also 12:36–37; 13:35). Because of this, Mark's audience would understand the statement as referring to the Lord Jesus Christ, who needed the colt (see also Romans 10:9; Philippians 2:11).

## Mark 11:4–6

The disciples obeyed the instructions of Jesus. They found everything just as he had said.

## Mark 11:7–8

- the colt … He sat on it: Compare Zechariah 9:9. Some of the people surely understood that they were witnessing the arrival of the Messiah (the Christ, God's chosen king).
- The disciples made a seat for Jesus by placing their outer garments (cloaks) on the colt. Other people spread clothing and branches from nearby trees along the road as an act of honor while Jesus rode into Jerusalem (see 1 Kings 1:38–48; 2 Kings 9:13).

## Mark 11:9–10

Hosanna: Hosanna comes from a Hebrew expression that means "save, please" or "please save us." By the first century AD, Hosanna was not used as a literal cry for rescue from enemies. Instead, it had become an expression of joy and celebration (like the phrase used today, "Praise the Lord!"). For the people, it was an enthusiastic welcome for a famous traveler, "the prophet from Nazareth in Galilee" (Luke 19:38–40; Matthew 21:11).

The miracle of raising Lazarus from the dead might have contributed to the excitement of the day (John 12:9–11). But even the disciples did not fully understand this event until later (John 12:16).

For Jesus, this event was a fulfillment of prophecy. Jesus prepared for the occasion carefully and offered himself to the people of Israel as the Messiah (the Christ, God's chosen king).

## Mark 11:11

The account ends in a surprising way. The excited crowd disappears, and the actual entrance of Jesus into the temple seems quiet compared to his approach. In the minds of the people, nothing important appeared to have happened. Jesus looks around the temple, preparing the audience for God's judgment on it (11:15–17).

## Mark 11:12–25

- In the Gospels of Matthew, Mark, and Luke, the entry of Jesus into Jerusalem as the Messiah is closely associated with the cleansing of the temple (see 11:15–17; compare Matthew 21:1–17; Luke 19:28–48). In John's Gospel, the cleansing of the temple occurs early in the ministry of Jesus (John 2:13–22).

It is uncertain whether there were two separate cleansings of the temple (an early event recorded in John and this later event recorded in Matthew, Mark, and Luke) or just one cleansing recorded at different times by John and the other gospel writers.

- In Mark's Gospel, the story of the cursed fig tree (Mark 11:12–14, 20–25) surrounds the story of Jesus cleansing the temple (11:15–19). This literary pattern, called an inclusio (a structure that places one story around another like bookends), shows that the

cleansing of the temple should be understood as an act of judgment, not simply an attempt to reform the temple.

## Mark 11:13–14

since it was not the season for figs: Jesus did not curse the fig tree simply because it had no fruit. Instead, he was performing a prophetic sign act, like the actions of earlier prophets (Isaiah 20; Jeremiah 13:1–11; 19:1–13; Ezekiel 4). A prophetic sign act is an action that teaches or announces God's message.

Just as Jesus judged the fruitless fig tree, he also judged the temple and Israel's worship, where he found no spiritual fruit. This judgment was fulfilled in AD 70, when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem and the temple.

## Mark 11:15–16

When they returned to the temple, Jesus was very upset about the buying and selling of sacrificial animals and the money exchange. It was supervised by priests, who alone could certify that a potential sacrificial offering was acceptable. Selling animals for sacrifices guaranteed that they only used animals that had no imperfections in temple services.

They placed exchange tables throughout Jerusalem and inside the temple. They did this on the fifteenth of Adar, the month before Passover. The exchange rate usually had a 4- to 8-percent fee. Because of the large number of half-shekels (see Exodus 30:11–16) and sacrifices involved, the money exchange and the sale of sacrificial animals was quite profitable.

Jewish writings of the time criticized priests for gaining wealth by taking advantage of poor people. Jesus did not oppose the temple or the system of sacrifices (Mark 1:44; Matthew 5:17–19, 23; 17:24–27; Luke 17:14; Acts 6:7; 21:20–26). But he saw this profit-making as theft. It did not honor the temple as a holy place.

The actions of Jesus likely affected fewer people than many think. These actions occurred in one area of the large Court of the Gentiles. Most people in other parts of the temple did not see it happen.

The lack of interference by the Roman authorities suggests that they did not observe the event or did not regard it as a riot or a political rebellion. At the trial of Jesus, they did not mention this action. It was not a big attempt to stop all activities like this, but it was a symbolic act pointing to the judgment that was coming upon the temple and the city.

## Mark 11:15–19

The largest area of the temple in Jerusalem was the Court of the Gentiles. Covered porches surrounded it. This was probably where the selling took place.

## Mark 11:16

to carry merchandise through the temple courts: People also misused the temple by using it as a quick way to get from one part of the city to another. Other rabbis also forbade this practice (see Mishnah Berakhot 9.5; see Josephus, Against Apion 2.8).

## Mark 11:17

Jesus quoted Isaiah 56:7 and Jeremiah 7:11 to explain his actions. The quotation from Isaiah highlights the temple's importance for Gentiles. The temple's design included the Court of the Gentiles, a place meant to help Gentiles come and worship the God of Israel and become part of God's people.

Jesus judged Israel's leaders because they were preventing Gentiles from properly using this part of the temple. They had turned a place meant to be a house of prayer for all nations into a den of robbers through dishonest business and profiteering.

## Mark 11:18

The leading priests and teachers of the law began planning to kill Jesus because they feared him. His strong influence on the people, the amazement caused by his actions, and the power of his teaching threatened their authority (see 3:6; 12:12; 14:1–2, 10–11). Their response showed that reform alone would not be enough. God's judgment was necessary.

## Mark 11:19

Jesus and His disciples went out: They likely went back to Bethany (11:11; 14:3).

## Mark 11:20–21

The power of Jesus to judge the fig tree showed his authority to bring the judgment on Jerusalem that he had already foretold. If the first people hearing Mark's Gospel received it in the late AD 60s, they would have known that Roman armies were already carrying out this prophetic judgment against Jerusalem.

## Mark 11:22–23

- Truly I tell you: Jesus is emphasizing the importance of his words.
- this mountain: This probably refers to the Temple Mount, not the Mount of Olives. The judgment of the

temple is the main focus in 11:12–25. Mark 12:9 will mention it again, and 13:1–37 describes it in detail. The reference to destroying the temple would later be raised at the trial (14:58) and crucifixion (15:29) of Jesus.

## Mark 11:24–25

- Two additional sayings on prayer are connected to 11:23 by the word believe.

In the first (11:24), we are told that we will receive what we ask for (see Matt 7:7) if we pray with the faith described in Mark 11:23.

- Forgiveness is the second condition for answered prayer. Only when we forgive others can our most important prayer, that God forgive us, be answered (Matthew 5:23–24; 6:12, 14–15; Luke 6:37; 11:4; compare Luke 7:41–43, 47; Ephesians 4:32; Colossians 3:13).

## Mark 11:27

- Upon returning again to Jerusalem (see 11:1, 11, 15), Jesus and the disciples entered the temple. The frequent repetition of Jerusalem reminds Mark's audience of what would soon take place there (10:32–34; see 8:31; 9:31; 14:1–16:8).
- In the temple, Jesus met the leading priests, the teachers of the law, and the elders. These three groups formed the 71-member high council, the main ruling body of the Jewish nation. Earlier passages already show these leaders opposing Jesus (8:31; see also 14:43, 53; 15:1), so their conflict with him here is not surprising.

## Mark 11:27–33

Jesus cleansed the temple (11:15–17; Matthew 21:12–22; Luke 19:45–46). Then his opponents questioned his authority to do so (see also Matt 21:23–27; Luke 20:1–8; compare John 2:18–22).

## Mark 11:28

Jesus has authority to:

- drive out demons (1:22, 27; 5:1–13),
- heal (1:29–2:12; 5:21–43),
- forgive sins (2:10), and
- cleanse the temple.

His authority came from God, but the religious leaders refused to accept it.

## Mark 11:29–30

Jesus often responded to his opponents' questions with other questions (for example, 2:8–9, 19, 25–26; 3:4, 23; 10:3, 38; see also 12:16). This is an effective way both to teach and to refute.

## Mark 11:31–32

Jesus placed his opponents in a difficult position. Either answer would hurt their authority and reputation with the people. If they denied that John was a prophet, the crowd would likely become angry. But if they admitted that John was a prophet, they would also have to accept what John said about Jesus. That answer would also respond to their own question about the authority of Jesus (11:28).

## Mark 11:33

We do not know: The religious leaders of the nation admitted that they could not answer a simple question that the people had no difficulty in answering: John was sent from God. This response showed the Jewish leaders were not fit to lead on this issue. Their stubbornness, lack of desire to understand, and refusal to accept the truth made further discussion without purpose (3:5; 7:6; 4:12).

God's judgment would come within that very generation (13:30) because of:

- their spiritual blindness and opposition toward God's servants, John the Baptist and Jesus,
- their lack of respect for the temple, and
- their plot to kill Jesus.

## Mark 12:1

- speak to them: This refers to the religious leaders mentioned earlier in 11:27 (also in 12:12).
- The beginning description of the story comes from Isaiah 5:1–7. The people Jesus was speaking to knew the book of Isaiah well. They would have quickly recognized this symbolic story, in which each part of the vineyard had a special meaning.

## Mark 12:1–12

- The events from 11:27–12:44 happen in the temple (see 11:27; 13:1). This story, or parable, is closely connected to the earlier question about the authority of Jesus (11:27–33). Mark introduces it with the words, "Then Jesus began to speak to them." The parable is the extended answer Jesus gives to the religious leaders.
- Jesus wanted his audience to understand this parable in the context of Isaiah 5:1–7. This tells a similar

story about planting a vineyard, building a lookout tower, putting up a fence, and digging a pit for a wine vat. Both stories also ask a similar question about what the owner will do next (Mark 12:9; compare Isaiah 5:4). In Isaiah, the vineyard clearly represents the people of Israel (Isaiah 5:7). In the same way, people hearing the parable would understand it as a story about Israel.

Several parts of the parable have symbolic meaning:
- The tenants represent Israel's leaders.
- The owner represents God.
- The servants represent the Old Testament prophets.
- The beloved son represents Jesus, the Son of God.
- The murder of the son points to the crucifixion of Jesus.
- The vineyard being given to others points to the judgment that would come upon Israel (Mark 11:15–17; 13:1–37).

Mark's audience would understand this explanation more clearly than the original audience hearing the words of Jesus. Even so, the religious leaders understood enough to realize that Jesus was speaking against them, and they began looking for a way to kill him (12:12).

## Mark 12:2–5

- The grape harvest likely refers to the time when a new vineyard produces its first crop, about four years after planting. The owner would receive grapes or wine as payment for leasing the vineyard.
- In the Old Testament, prophets are often referred to as servants (Jeremiah 7:25–26; Amos 3:7; Zechariah 1:6). Israelite leaders frequently treated them badly and killed them (1 Kings 18:13; 19:10, 14; 2 Chronicles 24:20–27; 36:15–16; Jeremiah 26:20–23; Nehemiah 9:26; see Matthew 23:34, 37; 1 Thessalonians 2:15).

## Mark 12:6

Mark's early audience would have quickly connected beloved son with Jesus (compare 1:11; 9:7; see also 1:1; 3:11; 5:7).

## Mark 12:7

The reasoning of the tenants is unclear to us, although it was apparently clear to the original hearers, requiring no further explanation (compare Matthew 21:38; Luke 20:14). Perhaps when the son arrived, the tenants thought the father had died. They may have believed that if they killed the son, no rightful owner would remain. Then the vineyard might become theirs, since they had worked it for many years.

## Mark 12:8

threw him out of the vineyard: This action shows even more dishonor, because they did not bury him. Compare with Hebrews 13:12–13.

## Mark 12:9

The parable ends with two rhetorical questions (compare 3:23, 33; 4:13; 7:18; 8:12). The first question matches the response of the "LORD of Hosts" in Isaiah's parable of the vineyard (Isaiah 5:5–7).

Some interpreters believe Jesus meant that God would replace the unfaithful Jewish leaders (Mark 11:27; 12:12) with faithful leaders. However, the first people hearing Mark's Gospel likely understood the others who would receive the vineyard to include the Gentile church (compare Matthew 21:43; Romans 9:25–33; 11:13–24).

In this way, the parable of Jesus is connected to the coming destruction of Jerusalem (Mark 11:15–19; 13:1–37; 14:58; 15:29).

## Mark 12:10–11

In his second rhetorical question, Jesus quoted Psalm 118:22–23. The stone the builders rejected, representing the Son, has become the cornerstone of God's kingdom (compare Acts 4:11; 1 Peter 2:4, 6–7). Traditionally, this phrase refers to a cornerstone buried in the foundation. But it could also mean the capstone at the top of a building, marking its completion. In either case, it was the most important stone.

Although the builders, representing the religious leaders, rejected the stone, their actions still took place according to God's will (Acts 4:28). God used even their evil intentions to accomplish his plan, which is wonderful to see. Those who put Jesus to death became instruments in God's purpose for the Son of Man "to give His life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45).

## Mark 12:12

the leaders: For the second time, the crowd stopped their evil plans (see 11:31–32; 14:1–2).

## Mark 12:13–17

After they failed to question the authority of Jesus, his enemies tried to turn the people against him. From the beginning, it is clear that the Pharisees and the supporters of Herod (see 3:6) were not sincere. They were trying to trap Jesus so he would say something that could lead to his arrest.

The question Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar or not? was carefully planned. It put Jesus in a difficult situation where any answer seems wrong. If he said yes, the people might turn against him, because they hated Roman rule and taxes. If he said no, he could

## Mark 12:14

taxes: The Greek word refers to a poll tax, a tax each person paid to the government (compare Luke 2:1–2 and Acts 5:37).

## Mark 12:15

- Jesus gave a surprising response that showed his wisdom.
- a denarius: The tax likely had to be paid using Roman coins.

## Mark 12:16

The picture and title on the coin were almost certainly of Tiberius Caesar, who ruled from AD 14 to 37. The inscription (words written on the coin) said, "Tiberius Caesar Augustus, Son of [the] Divine Augustus" on one side and "High Priest" on the other.

## Mark 12:17

Give to Caesar what is Caesar's: The words of Jesus should not be understood as support for anti-Roman revolutionaries who opposed paying taxes to Caesar. Elsewhere, Jesus clearly rejected the violent goals of such groups (see Matthew 5:9, 39, 41; 26:52).

At the same time, Jesus was not simply supporting Roman rule. Loyalty and service to God come first because God's authority is greater than Caesar's. Like the evil tenants in the previous parable, the religious leaders had failed to give God what rightly belonged to him.

## Mark 12:18

This is the only place in Mark where the Sadducees are mentioned by name, although they are included in references to the leading priests (see 8:31; 10:33; 11:18, 27). Sadducees did not believe in the resurrection from the dead (see Acts 4:1–2; 23:8).

## Mark 12:18–27

- This is the third controversy story of the series begun in 11:27. As in most New Testament references to the Sadducees, the setting is the temple (Matthew 22:23–33; Luke 20:27–40; Acts 4:1–3; 5:12, 17; 22:30–23:10; the exceptions are Matthew 3:7; 16:1–12).
- The Sadducees' question (Mark 12:19–23) was carefully crafted and based on a commandment of Moses (Deuteronomy 25:5–6; see Genesis 38:6–11; Ruth 4:1–22). Since all seven men could not have the woman as wife in the resurrection, and since none of them had a special claim, the Sadducees thought that they had proven the absurdity of the doctrine of the resurrection and refuted the Pharisees and Jesus (compare Matthew 12:41–42; Luke 16:19–31; see also Mark 8:31; 9:31; 10:34).

## Mark 12:19

- The Sadducees based their views only on the books of Moses (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy).
- Like the Pharisees (12:14), they addressed Jesus as Teacher. The Sadducees often debated with religious teachers (see Josephus, Antiquities 18.1.4).

## Mark 12:24–27

- Jesus gave two answers. First, he corrected the Sadducees because they did not understand the Scriptures (the Old Testament). The resurrection of the dead is shown most clearly in the Prophets (Isaiah 26:19; Ezekiel 37:1–14) and the Writings (Job 19:26; Psalms 16:9–11; 49:15; 73:23–26; Daniel 12:2). But the Sadducees accepted only the Torah (Genesis, Exodus, Numbers, Leviticus, and Deuteronomy). So Jesus answered them from the Torah.

God called himself "the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob" (Exodus 3:6, 15–16). This showed that God's covenant (binding relationship) with the patriarchs could not be ended by death. Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were still alive to God (Matthew 8:11–12; 13:17; Luke 16:19–31; John 8:56). God is the God of the living, not the dead. This means that God's relationship with his people continues after physical death.

- Second, Jesus corrected the Sadducees because they did not understand God's power. They thought resurrection life would be the same as mortal life. But resurrection life is new and different. In that life, people will not need sexual reproduction because there will be no more death. Marriage will no longer have the same role. Believers will share full fellowship with God and with all God's people (Mark 10:29–30; Matthew 19:28–29; Luke 18:29–30; Revelation 21:1–4). In this way, resurrected believers will be like the angels in heaven.
- The answer Jesus gave shows his wisdom before his opponents. It also confirmed the hope of resurrection for his followers. Jesus is "the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25). He has defeated death. He

promises that all who believe in him will "not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16).

## Mark 12:28

"Which commandment is the most important of all?": The Torah (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy) contains 613 separate commandments, and Jewish teachers frequently debated about which were more important than others. No command was considered unimportant, but some were recognized as more fundamental than others (see Matthew 22:40).

Rabbi Hillel's answer to this question was, "What is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor" (Babylonian Shabbat 31a; see also Tobit 4:15). Other suggestions included Proverbs 3:6; Isaiah 33:15–16; 56:1; Amos 5:4; Micah 6:8; and Habakkuk 2:4.

## Mark 12:28–34

After the three hostile challenges in 11:27–12:27, we might expect the next question to Jesus to be hostile (see 11:28; 12:13, 15, 19–23). However, this question was different. Earlier in Mark, the teachers of religious law usually opposed Jesus (2:6–7, 16; 3:22; 7:1, 5; 8:31; 9:14; 10:33; 11:18, 27). Jesus also warned the crowds about their lack of honesty (12:38–40). But this teacher spoke respectfully to Jesus and even praised him (12:28, 32–33). Jesus said the man answered wisely and was "not far from the kingdom of God" (12:34).

## Mark 12:29–31

- Jesus answered by joining two commands from different parts of the Torah.
- The first, Deuteronomy 6:4–5, was likely the most well-known passage in the Old Testament. Faithful Jews repeated it twice each day. It is called the Shema because it starts with the word Listen (Hebrew shema'). This command matches the first part of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:2–11), which focuses on a person's relationship with God.
- God's oneness is central to Jewish and Christian monotheism (belief in one God). It is the foundation for the command to love God fully—with all one's heart (thinking and affection), soul (desire and feeling), mind (understanding), and strength (energy and power).
- The second command comes from Leviticus 19:18. It matches the second part of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12–17), which concerns relationships with other people. This command is based on the natural tendency of people to care for themselves. Its importance in the early church is shown by how often it is repeated (Matthew 5:43–44; 19:19; 25:31–46; Romans 13:8–10; Galatians 5:14; James 2:8; Didache 1.2; 2.7).

These two commands are closely connected and together form one commandment. This connection rejects a mysticism concerned only with a person's relationship with God or a humanism concerned only with human relationships.

## Mark 12:32–33

The scribe's affirmation adds emphasis to the importance of these two commands for authentic devotion.

## Mark 12:34

The account ends with Jesus praising the teacher of religious law for understanding that these two commands were more important than burnt offerings and sacrifices (see Hosea 6:6). We remain uncertain about what happened to this man. He was close to the kingdom of God, but did he enter it? Mark might have left this question open so each person would consider, Have I entered the kingdom of God?

## Mark 12:35–37

After answering many questions, most of them from opponents, Jesus asked a question of his own (see 8:27; Matthew 17:25; 21:31; Luke 10:36). The Messiah was commonly called the Son of David because of passages like Isaiah 9:2–7; 11:1–5; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:15–16; Ezekiel 34:23–24; 37:24–28.

Jesus did not deny that the Messiah was a descendant of David (Mark 10:47–48; 11:10; see Romans 1:3–4). Instead, he showed that this title alone was not enough to describe the Messiah. The Messiah is much greater than only a son of David.

## Mark 12:36

Psalm 110:1 is the Old Testament verse most quoted in the New Testament. Since David wrote the psalm, the statement "The Lord [God] said to my [David's] Lord [the Messiah]," shows that the Messiah is David's Lord. So, the Messiah is not just David's son. He is the Son of God and Man who sits at God's right hand (Mark 14:62). He will come to judge the world (8:38; 13:24–27, 32–37).

## Mark 12:38–39

- the scribes: See 1:22. This warning is similar to the one against the Pharisees and Herod in 8:15. The scribes violated the two greatest commandments (12:30–31). They broke the first commandment by not

loving God and by seeking respect and praise for themselves instead of reserving it for God.
- long robes: These were likely clothes worn by religious men. To receive greetings perhaps meant being called Rabbi (see Matthew 23:7). The chief seats were in the front of the synagogue facing the congregation.

## Mark 12:40

- The teachers of religious law broke the second command by failing to love their neighbors, as was seen in their cheating widows of their property. They clearly were cheating the most vulnerable and needy people despite God's concern for widows (Deuteronomy 14:29; Psalms 68:5; 146:9; Isaiah 1:17; Jeremiah 7:6; 49:11) and his condemnation of those who mistreat them (Isaiah 1:23; Ezekiel 22:7; Zechariah 7:10; Malachi 3:5). The teachers of religious law showed false holiness through outward religious actions (see Matthew 6:5–6; Luke 18:11–12).
- These men will receive greater condemnation: This refers to the final judgment (Mark 9:42–48; see Luke 14:11).

## Mark 12:41–42

The word treasury can refer to a building in the temple area where they stored temple money. Here, it refers to one of thirteen money chests into which gifts were placed.

As Jesus watched, many rich people put in large amounts. Then, he noticed one poor widow who put in two small copper coins. (The Roman term quadrans suggests Mark wrote his Gospel for the church in Rome; see Mark Book Introduction, "Audience.") These two coins were worth only one sixty-fourth of a denarius, which was a normal day's pay (Matthew 20:1–2).

## Mark 12:41–44

This story about a poor widow shows the difference between the religious leaders who were not sincere and those who truly love God (12:38–40). The focus of the passage is on the statement from Jesus, Truly I tell you, where the widow is said to have given more than the rich people.

## Mark 12:43–44

Jesus called his disciples to hear his teaching (see 3:23; 6:7; 8:1; 10:42; see also 7:14; 8:34). In 12:43, Jesus showed a big difference between his thinking and that of the world. No one would have named a building after the widow for her gift of two small coins, but Jesus and his Father look at a person's heart (1 Samuel 16:7). The widow was doing exactly what Jesus told the rich young ruler to do (Mark 10:21) and what he taught his disciples (1:18, 20; 8:34–37; 10:28–29). Like the woman in 14:3–9, the poor widow loved God with all her heart, soul, mind, and strength (12:30).

## Mark 13:1

- After leaving the temple, Jesus went toward the Mount of Olives (13:3).
- look at the magnificent stones and buildings!: The Temple was an amazing sight. It was the largest temple complex in the world and was built with huge stones. One stone found in the western wall is estimated to weigh about 600 tons (544,314 kilograms or 1.2 million pounds)!

With its white stones, gold edges, and gold-covered roof, the Temple Complex resembled a mountain covered with snow. In the sun, it was a blinding sight (Josephus, War 5.5.6). The Jewish Talmud says that, "He who has not seen the temple in its full construction has never seen a glorious building in his life" (Babylonian Sukkah 51b).

## Mark 13:1–37

This passage brings to a conclusion the section begun at 11:1. Israel did not produce spiritual fruit (11:12–26; 12:38–40). Its leaders were opposed to God's chosen one, the Christ (11:1–11, 27–33; 12:13–17, 18–27). This would result in judgment and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple.

## Mark 13:2

- The reply from Jesus surprised the disciples. The great temple complex, which seemed to show strength, permanence, and God's favor toward the Jewish people, would be completely destroyed.
- Not one stone here will be left on another: The words of Jesus emphasized the total destruction that would come through the Roman army's attack on the temple complex (Josephus, Antiquities 6.9.1; 7.1.1.).

Some people argue that the prophecy was not fulfilled because a few foundation stones still remain. But this misunderstands prophetic language. A prophet would not normally speak in exact percentages or technical detail. Anyone who saw Jerusalem after AD 70 would have understood that the prophecy of Jesus had come true.

## Mark 13:3–4

- Andrew appeared here with the trio, Peter, James, and John (5:37; 9:2; 14:33) completing the two sets of brothers (1:16–20; 3:16–18).
- The prediction of Jesus inspired two questions from the disciples. Although some scholars argue that the second question goes beyond the first in looking to the coming of the Son of Man at the end of the age, it is best to interpret these two questions as focusing on the time and the sign associated with the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple (compare 13:29–30; Luke 21:7).

These questions follow naturally from the prediction of Jesus in Mark 13:2. The disciples wanted to know the sign to have a warning so they would be ready for all these events.

## Mark 13:5–6

Jesus warned his followers not to be deceived by false messiahs. Many people would come claiming, 'I am He,' and would lead many others astray. These people claimed either to be the long-awaited Jewish Messiah or to speak with the Messiah's authority.

Some examples include

- Theudas the Galilean (Acts 5:36),
- Simon, the son of Gioras, and
- John of Gischala, who tricked many people in the AD 60s.

## Mark 13:5–23

- Scholars often divide this section into two parts, 13:5–13 and 13:14–23. The first part is often interpreted as describing the destruction of Jerusalem, which occurred in AD 70, while the second part is taken to describe the coming of the Son of Man in the future. It is best, however, to interpret all of 13:5–23 as describing events surrounding the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 because:

1. 13:5–23 is the answer from Jesus to the two questions (13:4) that deal with the destruction of Jerusalem (13:2);
2. The commands to flee Judea (13:14–16), the woe announced upon pregnant and nursing women (13:17), and the prayer that it not take place in winter (13:18) make sense if they refer to the events of AD 70 but not if they refer to the future return of Christ;
3. Three warnings connect this passage (13:5, 9, 23) connect this passage together and show that 13:5–23 should be understood as a unit.

- The section is arranged as a chiasm (a literary pattern shaped like an X). The themes appear in this order:
- A: Deceivers claim to be the Messiah (13:5–6).
- B: There are reports of fighting and natural disasters (13:7–8).
- C: There is persecution of believers (13:9–13).
- B': The fighting in Judea and resulting suffering begin (13:14–20).
- A': Deceivers claim to be the Messiah (13:21–23).

## Mark 13:7

- The Greek word translated must is also used in 8:31. In both places, the word emphasizes God's control and authority over events.
- but the end is still to come: These events would happen before Jerusalem's destruction. Jesus compared them to birth pains, which come before childbirth. In the same way, these troubles would come before God's judgment on Jerusalem. However, they did not mean that the destruction would happen at once.

## Mark 13:9

- The second use of be on your guard warns of persecution that was to come upon Christians (see 6:11; 8:34–38; 10:30; see 4:17). They would bring Jewish Christians before local courts of the councils of Jewish leaders, who had authority over Jewish communities (see Matthew 10:17 and possibly Matthew 5:22; see also Acts 4:1–22).
- beaten in the synagogues: The apostle Paul's beatings in 2 Corinthians 11:24–25 likely happened in the synagogue.
- These trials occurred because they followed Jesus (see Acts 23:24; 24:10–27; 25:1–26:32): Such trials were due to their being followers of Jesus (Mark 13:9, 13). It was not because they actually did something wrong (see 1 Peter 4:14–16).

## Mark 13:10

Such trials (13:9, 11) would be a means through which the good news about Jesus would be preached to all nations. This would all take place first (before the destruction of Jerusalem). For Paul's understanding of how the good news had already been preached to every nation in his day, see Romans 16:26; Colossians 1:6, 23 (see also Romans 1:5, 8; 10:18; 15:19, 23).

## Mark 13:11

A word of encouragement follows the warning of 13:9. The followers of Jesus need not fear what they should say in these circumstances. The early followers of Jesus were generally uneducated and without political influence (see Acts 4:10–17; 1 Corinthians 1:26). So, this assurance would have comforted them. Believers are not prohibited from thinking about what they will say, but they need not worry about it.

## Mark 13:12–13

There was no group, not even their own families, to whom persecuted Christians could always go for help (see Matthew 10:35–36; Luke 12:53). All people would hate them because they were loyal to Jesus (because of My name). Those who remain faithful to Jesus until death (to the end) will be saved to eternal life (see also Mark 8:35; Revelation 2:7, 10, 17, 26–28; 3:5, 12, 21).

## Mark 13:14

- When you see the abomination of desolation: Mark did not explain what this object would be, but Jewish audiences in the first century were familiar with the term. The prophet Daniel had foretold that such an object would stand in the temple in Jerusalem (Daniel 9:27; 11:31). Many Jews understood the events in Jerusalem from 167 to 164 BC, during the time of Antiochus IV Epiphanes, to be a fulfillment of that prophecy.

The deuterocanonical book of 1 Maccabees (a book accepted as Scripture by some Christian traditions), was written around 100 BC. It tells about the rule of Antiochus. It says that Antiochus and his followers set up "sacrilegious object causing desecration on top of the altar for burnt offerings," 1 Maccabees 1:54, 59).

- standing where it should not be: Given the historical context and references to Jerusalem and Judea, this phrase clearly refers to something inappropriate happening in the temple in Jerusalem (Mark 13:2, 4,14).
- (let the reader understand): Mark urged his readers to focus on this sign, indicating it required careful thought and understanding. Mark wanted his audience to watch for a sign similar to what happened during the time of Antiochus Epiphanes.
- Although the phrase the abomination of desolation is grammatically neuter, the word standing is grammatically masculine. This may suggest a person behind the act, but it is not certain. The phrase can still refer to a thing or event.

Scholars suggest several possible meanings for the abomination of desolation. These include:

1. The emperor Caligula. In AD 39–40, he tried to place a statue of himself in the temple (Josephus, Antiquities 12.8.2–3).
2. Pontius Pilate, governor of Judea from AD 26–36. He brought Roman soldiers into Judea carrying military flags that Jews saw as idolatrous (Josephus, War 2.9.2–3).
3. The Zealots, a Jewish revolutionary group. Around AD 69–70, they committed violent acts in the temple, chose an unqualified high priest, "entered the sanctuary with polluted feet" (Josephus, War 4.3.4–8).
4. The Roman general Titus. After he conquered Jerusalem in AD 70, he forced entry into the temple (Josephus, War 6.4.7).
5. Titus' soldiers. They set up their military flags in the temple, offered sacrifices to them, and declared Titus emperor (Josephus, War 6.6.1).
6. The destruction of the temple itself in AD 70.
7. A future event. Some connect this to the coming of the antichrist (a future opponent of God; see 2 Thessalonians 2:3–4).

The context and source of this expression help us rule out some of these views. In Daniel and 1 Maccabees, the phrase refers to the Temple, its altar, and its sacrifices. In Mark 13:14–20, it is a sign that tells people to flee Judea. This sign must happen while there is still time to escape (before the Roman army surrounds Jerusalem).

Explanations 1 and 2 are too early. They would not have been a clear sign to flee Judea. They also did not actually defile the temple, and Christians did not leave Jerusalem at that time.

Explanations 4–6 are too late. They happened after Titus entered Jerusalem. By then, there was no time left to escape.

Explanation 7 refers to a future event. It does not match the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, which is the focus of 13:14–20. Also, the coming of the antichrist would not be limited to Judea.

Explanation 3 fits best. It took place in AD 69–70, shortly before Titus surrounded Jerusalem. This timing would have allowed a short time for Christians to leave the city. It also involved actions that defiled the holy place in the temple.

This view also helps distinguish between the sign and what happens next. The sign is the abomination of desolation, and what happens next is the great suffering and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple.

- then: At the appearance of the abomination, those in Judea were to flee to the mountains. The early church historian Eusebius says that a prophetic message (a message from God) was given to the church in Jerusalem. This message caused them to leave the city before it was destroyed (Eusebius, Church History 3.5.3).

## Mark 13:14–20

Jesus now gave the sign requested in 13:4 and instructed his followers how to respond when they saw it. In 13:5–13, they were told not to be alarmed. Here they are told that those in Judea must flee to the hills.

## Mark 13:15–16

A person relaxing on the roof of their Judean home should not even pack after seeing this sign, but come down and flee. Likewise, a person out in the field should not return home to retrieve his cloak. Believers were to flee from the approaching Roman army as soon as they saw the sign of 13:14.

Their movement was usually cautious, methodical (careful and step-by-step), and relentless (steady and not stopping). But Jesus warned people not to wait and see how things would develop.

## Mark 13:17

The suffering of the weakest (pregnant and nursing mothers) shows that the coming disaster would be severe. On that day, the joy of being a mother would be accompanied by terrible trouble (see Luke 1:25, 57–59).

## Mark 13:18

In winter, the wadis (canyon-like riverbeds) are flooded, travel is more difficult, and survival is harder.

## Mark 13:19

- For those will be days of tribulation unseen from the beginning of God's creation until now: This kind of hyperbole (intentional exaggeration for emphasis) is common in Hebrew and Aramaic patterns of speech. It emphasizes the terror of that time and should not be understood as a precise comparison with every other disaster in history.
- and never to be seen again: The events of 13:14–23 would not end human history. History continued after the destruction of the temple in AD 70.

## Mark 13:20

- God's shortening of this time of suffering is mentioned often in Jewish writings written between the Old and New Testaments (for example, 2 Esdras 2:13; 2 Baruch 20:1). This statement emphasizes both the terrible suffering of God's people during this tribulation (a time of great trouble) and God's mercy in shortening those days.
- nobody would be saved: The whole population of Judea might have died if this time of suffering had lasted longer.
- elect: These are followers of Jesus.

## Mark 13:21–23

- The larger section (13:5–23) ends with another warning about false messiahs. In this passage, these false leaders are connected with the events leading up to AD 70. In 13:5–6, however, they are connected more generally with ongoing events in history. Along with false messiahs, false prophets would appear and perform signs and wonders (13:22).

Jesus warned his followers not to believe such claims. When the Messiah comes from heaven, "every eye will see Him" (13:26; see Revelation 1:7).

- be on your guard: This warning unifies the section (Mark 13:5–23) and brings it to a close. Jesus gave this teaching to warn his followers in Judea and Jerusalem not to be misled by false hopes and false messianic claims. Many Jews accepted such claims in the late AD 60s.

Josephus describes the great harm caused by these false leaders, who encouraged the Jewish people to fight against the Romans (Antiquities 17.10.8). Christians were not to let anything stop them from fleeing Judea and Jerusalem when they saw the abomination of desolation.

- For Mark's audience in Rome, the message of Jesus had a different application. Mark wanted his audience to be careful of people who claimed to know when the fulfillment of prophecy would occur. They could not know the time (13:32).

Jesus also forbade unhealthy excitement about his second coming. Instead, believers were to stay alert (13:33–37) and prepare for persecution (9–13; see 8:34–38). They were to trust the words of encouragement Jesus spoke (13:11, 13).

## Mark 13:24–25

Some of the language the New Testament uses to describe the second coming of Jesus, such as "the trumpet of God" (1 Thessalonians 4:16), may be metaphorical (word pictures rather than literal descriptions). In the Old Testament, cosmic language is also often used metaphorically to describe historical events (see Isaiah 11:1–9; 13:9–11; Jeremiah 4:23–28; Ezekiel 32:1–16).

Because of this, some interpreters believe the imagery in Mark 13:24–27 could refer to a past event, such as the destruction of Jerusalem.

However, New Testament writers clearly understood the coming of the Son of Man to mean the future, visible, and personal return of Jesus (see Acts 1:9–11).

## Mark 13:24–27

But in those days, after that tribulation: Many scholars think this passage uses symbolic or figurative language. They believe the signs in the sky 13:24–25), the coming of the Son of Man (13:26), and the gathering of God's chosen people (13:27) all point to Jerusalem's destruction in AD 70. They also believe this event showed that the Son of Man had been proved right.

However, the traditional interpretation is different. It says that the earlier verses refer to the destruction of Jerusalem, but this passage refers to the coming of the Son of Man. This coming, called the parousia (the return of Christ), will happen at the end of history.

This interpretation fits better for several reasons:

1. After the anguish of those days means after the destruction of Jerusalem, not during it, and at that time (literally in those days) could occur at any time after the events of 13:5–23.
2. Several words used in 13:26 are used elsewhere to describe the coming of the Son of Man: glory (8:38), power and clouds (14:62).
3. Because of the early church's longing and praying for the return of the Lord Jesus (1 Corinthians 16:22; Rev 22:20), Mark's audience would have interpreted Mark 13:26 as the second coming of Jesus, which will bring history as we know it to a close.

The prophets, Jesus, and the Gospel writers described these events as if they were seen together from far away. Because of this, the time between the events is not always clear. No one knows when these things will happen except God himself (13:32). The events of 13:5–23 and 13:24–27 are part of one great act of God. This act includes the coming of the Son of Man, his ministry, death, and resurrection, the judgment of Jerusalem in AD 70, and the Son of Man's final coming in glory.

## Mark 13:27

When the Son of Man comes, he will gather his chosen people. These are those who believe in him and follow him. His chosen people come from all over the world and from the farthest parts of the earth and heaven (see Zechariah 2:6; see Deuteronomy 13:7; 30:4; Isaiah 42:10; 62:11). This hope is expressed frequently in the Old Testament (for example, Psalm 107:2–3; Isaiah 11:11–16; 27:12–13; 43:5–13; 49:12; 60:1–9; Jeremiah 31:10).

For Mark's audience, this passage would have encouraged them to endure and remain faithful despite the persecutions foretold in Mark 13:9–13. The coming of the Son of Man will also bring judgment on the unrighteous (see 8:38; 13:32–37; Matthew 13:41–43; 24:36–51; 25:1–12, 31–46).

## Mark 13:28–31

This passage contains the lesson (literally parable) of the fig tree (13:28–30) and two sayings (13:30–31). It is closely connected to 13:4–23 by the words "these things" in 13:4 and "when you see" in 13:29 (compare 13:14).

## Mark 13:29

He is near: The Greek text has no clear subject, so the choice between he is near or it is near depends on whether 13:29–30 refers to 13:4–23 or 13:24–27. The Berean Standard Bible understands it as referring to the return of the Son of Man.

Since some words in 13:4 appear again in 13:29 and 30 (see study note on 13:28–31), others interpret it as referring to the destruction of Jerusalem. Just as the first leaves of a fig tree signal summer, "the abomination of desolation" (13:14) would signal Jerusalem's destruction.

## Mark 13:30

This generation would see these events happen. That generation did see the destruction of Jerusalem. However, people who believe that all these things includes the coming of the Son of Man must understand this generation in another way, not simply as the people living at that time.

Some think it refers to the Jewish people continuing to exist through history. Others believe it means the whole human race, the Christian community, or the final generation living at the end of the age.

## Mark 13:31

Jesus personally guaranteed what he had said. My words include what Jesus said in Mark 13:1–37. Mark's audience would have understood this as guaranteeing the truth of all the teachings of Jesus known to them (Luke 1:2).

Like the Old Testament Scriptures (see Isa 40:8), the words of Jesus are eternal. His teachings are more permanent than the basic parts of creation itself. The basic elements of creation will pass away (see also Ps

102:25–26; Isa 40:6–8; 51:6; Matt 5:18; Luke 16:17; 2 Pet 3:7, 10; Rev 20:11), but the words of Jesus will never disappear.

## Mark 13:32

- No one knows about that day or hour: This statement introduces the warning to be watchful (compare Acts 1:7) and not to make guesses about the exact time of these events (Mark 13:33–37).
- Jesus calls himself the Son who ranks above the angels in an order that begins with no one and ends with only the Father. The authenticity of this saying is supported by the limitation it places on the Son's knowledge. The early church would not likely have invented such a statement. In later apocryphal gospels (books outside the New Testament written around AD 150–300), writers usually increased and praised the divine attributes of Jesus (for example, the Infancy Gospel of Thomas).

In the miracle of the incarnation, Jesus experienced limitation (Mark 10:40; 13:32). If the Son himself did not know the day or hour, Christians should refrain from seeking such knowledge for themselves.

## Mark 13:32–37

Just as 13:28–31 returns to the theme of 13:5–23 by speaking about the destruction of Jerusalem, 13:32–37 appears to return to the theme of 13:24–27 by speaking about the coming of the Son of Man.

The section begins with a warning against trying to predict the end time (13:32). This is followed by a warning to stay alert because no one knows when the end will come (13:33).

Jesus then tells a parable (a short teaching story) to show the need to be ready for the Lord's return (13:34). The application of the parable repeats the warning to stay watchful so that believers will not be found unprepared (13:35–36). The section ends with another call to remain watchful (13:37).

## Mark 13:33–37

These verses repeat a basic warning: Be on your guard and stay alert! ... Keep watch! The repetition shows that they needed to stay alert (be watchful and ready).

## Mark 13:34–35

- The point of this parable is not that the Lord's return is doubtful or completely unexpected (see Matthew 24:45–51; 25:1–30; Luke 12:36–38; 19:12–27). Rather, it teaches that there will be no warning sign before he comes. The parable uses symbolic language in at least two ways:
- The master (Greek kurios, "lord" or "master") represents the Lord Jesus Christ.
- The servants represent the Christian community.

However, interpreting the doorkeeper as the apostles or Peter developed later, after the New Testament period.

- at midnight, when the rooster crows, or in the morning: These four times match the Roman division of the night into four watches of about three hours each. They simply mean that the master may return at any time during the night.

## Mark 13:37

- This passage was first spoken to the disciples (you, see also 13:5), but it is also directed to everyone who hears or reads the Gospel of Mark (everyone).

- Keep watch!: Although 13:32–37 warns believers to be ready, the early church understood this watchfulness as joyful expectation for "the blessed hope and glorious appearance of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ" (Titus 2:13). Even Greek-speaking Christians in the first century used the Aramaic prayer Marana tha ("Come, Lord," see 1 Corinthians 16:22; Revelation 22:20). Christians today still "crave His appearing" (2 Timothy 4:8).

## Mark 14:1–2

The leading priests and the teachers of the law had planned to kill Jesus (see 3:6; 11:18; 12:12). Now their plan reaches its final stage.

## Mark 14:1–16.8

The last section of Mark tells the story of the suffering, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

## Mark 14:3–9

- The story of Jesus's anointing by a woman in Bethany (14:3–9) introduces the events that follow. Luke's account (Luke 7:36–50) is quite different and may describe another event. This incident took place in Bethany, a village about 3.2 kilometers (2 miles) east of Jerusalem on the lower eastern slope of the Mount of Olives. Jesus apparently stayed there when he was in Judea (Mark 11:1, 11–12).

The house belonged to Simon, a man who had previously had leprosy (a disease that often caused people to be separated from society). He may have been healed by Jesus (see 1:40–45).

- reclining ("sitting back"): The meal was a banquet because the guests were reclining while they ate. A woman (see John 12:3) broke the neck of a sealed alabaster jar filled with expensive perfume (pure nard) and poured all of it on the head of Jesus (see Exodus 29:4–7; 2 Kings 9:1–6).

## Mark 14:4–5

Some people (see Matthew 26:8; John 12:4–5) were angry because they thought the expensive perfume had been wasted. The perfume was said to be worth about a year's wages for an average worker. They argued that the money could have been given to the poor. Giving to the poor was especially important during Passover.

## Mark 14:6–8

Jesus defended the woman's action. That the disciples would always have the poor among them did not minimize the concern Jesus has for the poor. The opportunity to minister directly to Jesus was limited. Only hours remained! She chose the best thing she could do with her perfume.

## Mark 14:8

Jesus explains the woman's action. She had anointed his body in preparation for burial. It is not clear whether the woman understood that the death of Jesus was near, but her loving act served the purpose Jesus described.

## Mark 14:9

Mark's Gospel does not mention the woman's name, but her action is remembered as people share the story of Jesus worldwide (14:6).

## Mark 14:10–11

In clear contrast to the woman who anointed Jesus with perfume, Judas Iscariot, one of the Twelve disciples, offered to betray Jesus for money (Matthew 26:15; 27:3, 9).

## Mark 14:12

The Jews sacrificed the lamb for Passover at twilight on the 14th day of the Jewish month of Nisan (Exodus 12:6). This date occurs in March or April each year.

## Mark 14:12–32

- The preparation for the Passover meal (14:12–16) introduces the story of the Last Supper (22–25).
- The Last Supper is associated with the Passover meal (14:12, 14, 16; Matthew 26:17–19; Luke 22:7–8, 11, 13, 15; compare John 18:28; 19:14). Many people traveled to Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover. This was where God's temple was located (see Deuteronomy 16:2).

## Mark 14:13–15

The instructions Jesus gives to the disciples are similar to those in 11:2–6. This suggests that Jesus had already arranged a place where he and his disciples could eat the Passover meal and the Last Supper together. The careful preparation for this meal shows its importance.

The two disciples were to prepare the Passover meal. This included:

- the lamb (which had to be slaughtered, skinned, cleaned, and roasted over an open fire),
- unleavened bread,
- a bowl of salt water,
- bitter herbs, and
- a fruit mixture called kharosheth.

Enough wine mixed with water was needed so that Jesus and the disciples could each drink four cups. These cups celebrated God's fourfold blessing (Exodus 6:6–7).

## Mark 14:17

In the evening, Jesus arrived with the twelve disciples at the upstairs guest room. The Twelve refers to the disciples of Jesus as a group. Ten arrived with Jesus, since two were already there (14:13).

## Mark 14:18

- while they were reclining: the Passover meal was eaten while reclining, as was common at banquet meals. During the meal, someone (usually the youngest son) would ask the host, "Why is this night different from other nights?" The father or host would then tell the stories of the Passover and the exodus from Egypt (Deuteronomy 26:5–9).

The foods in the Passover meal had symbolic meaning:

- The Passover lamb reminded the people of the blood of the sacrificial lambs that protected Israelite homes from the angel of death in Egypt (Exodus 12:28–30).
- The unleavened bread reminded them of the Israelites' quick departure from Egypt (Exodus 12:31–34, 39).
- The salt water represented both the tears of slavery and the crossing of the Red Sea. The bitter herbs represented the bitterness of slavery.

- The four cups of wine recalled God's fourfold promise in Exodus 6:6–7.
- The betrayal of Jesus was especially terrible because the betrayer was one of those eating with him (see Psalms 41:9; 55:12–14).

## Mark 14:19

Surely note I?: The disciples were shocked and saddened. This was the first time they heard someone would be unfaithful to Jesus and give him over to the Jewish leaders. Jesus kept the one who betrayed him a secret (though Mark first mentioned it in 3:19).

## Mark 14:21

will go just as it is written about Him: See, for example, Isaiah 52:13–53:12. Jesus knew ahead of time that this betrayal would happen as part of God's plan (compare 8:31–33). But God condemned the one who betrayed him. Jesus and the gospel writers do not explain how God's sovereignty (God's rule and control over all things) and Judas's human responsibility fit together. Yet both truths are clearly affirmed (see John 19:11).

## Mark 14:22–25

- The Last Supper began with a blessing. Today, many Christians ask God to bless the food before a meal. In the time of Jesus, Jewish people commonly blessed God for providing the food by saying, "Blessed are you, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who brings forth bread from the earth."
- this is My body ... This is My blood: Ever since the Protestant Reformation, there have been three main interpretations of the words of Jesus about the bread and wine:

1. Transubstantiation: The bread and wine are believed to change into the actual body and blood of Christ, while still appearing to be bread and wine.
2. Real Presence: Christ is understood to be truly present in the sacrament in a mysterious but real way that is beyond human understanding.
3. Memorial or Symbolic View: The bread and wine are seen as symbols. The act of sharing them recalls Christ's death and resurrection, and believers receive spiritual benefit through faith.

See also John 6:53–63.

## Mark 14:24

The cup of wine represented the blood of Jesus, poured out as a sacrifice (10:45; Isaiah 53:12). It initiated the covenant that God has made with his people (Luke 22:20; 1 Corinthians 11:25; see Exodus 24:8; Zechariah 9:11; Hebrews 9:18–20; 10:26–29). The term many refers to all people (see Mark 10:45; Romans 5:15–19).

## Mark 14:25

when I drink it anew: Jesus will have a great banquet (or feast) for his followers when he returns and fully establishes the kingdom of God.

## Mark 14:26–27

- When they had sung a hymn: It was customary to end the Passover by singing the last part of the hallel psalms (Psalms 114–118).
- The singing of hymns brought the Passover meal and Last Supper to a conclusion, and Jesus and the disciples departed for the Mount of Olives to spend the night. As they proceeded, Jesus told his disciples that they would all desert him, which had to happen because the Scriptures foretold it.
- I will strike the Shepherd: As a result, the sheep (the disciples) would be scattered.

## Mark 14:28

Despite predictions of their failure, the account included encouragement and hope. After Jesus was raised from the dead, he met the disciples in Galilee (see 16:7). There, they were forgiven and restored (see John 21:1–23).

## Mark 14:29–31

Peter protested, and Jesus rebuked him, as in 8:32–33. Even though Peter strongly objected, he denied Jesus only a few hours later.

## Mark 14:32

Gethsemane means "oil press" in Aramaic. Gethsemane is still full of olive trees today. John 18:1 calls it a garden. Luke 22:39 shows it was a favorite place for Jesus and his disciples.

## Mark 14:33–34

Jesus went ahead with Peter, James, and John (5:37–43; 9:2–9; see also 13:3). They asked them to keep watch and pray with him, sharing in his distress.

## Mark 14:35–36

- Jesus fell to the ground to pray because of his deep distress (see Genesis 17:1–3; Leviticus 9:24; Numbers 14:5; 16:4). Since it was normal to pray out loud, Jesus was probably overheard by the three disciples, who would not have fallen asleep immediately.

- Jesus addressed God as Abba, Father, indicating their close relationship (see Romans 8:15; Galatians 4:6).
- Take this cup from me: In faith, Jesus expressed his own feelings and desires to the Father. It was not only the physical pain of crucifixion that terrified him, but also the unique death that he would experience. He "who knew no sin" would experience the wrath of God against sin (Mark 15:34; 2 Corinthians 5:21; Galatians 3:13).
- Yet not what I will, but what You will: The submission of Jesus to the Father's will is a model for his followers.

## Mark 14:37–38

- Are you asleep?: The question was a rebuke, for Jesus knew that Peter had been sleeping.
- Though the spirit is willing to avoid temptation (see Romans 7:18, 22–23), the body (literally the flesh, which refers to the general weakness and vulnerability of humanity) is weak.

## Mark 14:41–42

- The content of the prayer of Jesus was likely the same as before (see 14:35–36, 39). Peter, James, and John failed to watch and pray three times. This recalls the prediction Jesus made that Peter would deny him three times (14:30, 66–72).
- Are you still sleeping and resting?: This phrase can be interpreted in several ways:
- As in the Berean Standard Bible, this phrase can be interpreted as a rhetorical question. This type of question expects a positive answer, something like, "Sadly, yes." This suggests that Jesus is expressing disappointment.
- Others understand it as a command. For example, the New Living Translation says, "Go ahead and sleep. Have your rest."
- Still others interpret it as an exclamation ("You are sleeping and resting!").
- the hour has come: The suffering of Jesus had begun. The time had come for the sacrificial Lamb to pour out his blood. (14:24). This happened as Judas arrived with the armed crowd that came to arrest Jesus. Jesus was betrayed into the hands of sinners, and he willingly went to the cross for them (2:17; 10:45; 14:21).
- Rise, let us go: Jesus accepted the cup God had given him. He went out to defeat his enemies by dying for them.

## Mark 14:43

Judas's betrayal during the arrest of Jesus becomes even more shocking when Mark reminds his audience that Judas was one of the 12 disciples. Judas had already agreed with the leading priests to betray Jesus at the right time and place (14:10–11).

He then led an armed crowd to arrest Jesus secretly at night, away from the people (14:1–2). Although the leaders wanted to avoid a public conflict, the crowd was large enough to stop any resistance from Jesus or his followers (see Luke 22:52; John 18:3).

## Mark 14:44–45

Gethsemane was dark, and most of the crowd sent to arrest Jesus did not know him personally (see John 18:7–8). Judas had given a sign by which he would identify Jesus. Judas called Jesus Rabbi and kissed him, a common form of greeting (1 Samuel 10:1; 2 Samuel 19:39; Luke 7:45).

## Mark 14:47

Peter tried to defend Jesus by cutting off the ear of the high priest's slave (see John 18:10; see Luke 22:50–51).

## Mark 14:49

But everything happening was to fulfill what the Scriptures say about Jesus. Mark reassured his audience that these events were part of God's plan. See Isaiah 53:7–9.

## Mark 14:50

As Jesus had predicted just hours earlier, all his disciples deserted him (14:27–31).

## Mark 14:51–52

The account of the arrest of Jesus ends with a note about an unnamed young man. There is no clear theological reason given for why Mark includes this detail. One possible explanation is that it is a personal detail from Mark himself, but this cannot be confirmed.

## Mark 14:53–54

The chief priests, elders, and scribes were not the same as "the whole Sanhedrin" (14:55; 15:1) but they made up a large part of it. Peter followed Jesus into the chief priest's courtyard, where the Sanhedrin was meeting. This prepares the audience for Peter's denial of Jesus later in the chapter (14:66–72).

## Mark 14:53–65

The account of the trial of Jesus begins immediately after his arrest. Some scholars have questioned whether the Gospel accounts are historically reliable because they differ in some details from the rules found in the Mishnah tractate Sanhedrin. However, several points should be considered.

1. The Mishnah was written around AD 200, while the Gospel of Mark was written in the late AD 60s, more than 130 years earlier.
2. The rules in Mishnah Sanhedrin describe what later rabbis believed should happen in such trials. They do not necessarily describe what actually happened.
3. It is uncertain whether the Sadducees who led the Sanhedrin would have followed the Pharisaic rules found in the Mishnah Sanhedrin (see Acts 23:6–10).
4. Some rules in the Mishnah Sanhedrin differ from what the Jewish historian Josephus wrote.
5. Laws were not always followed in practice. Jesus was being tried by a court that had already decided the outcome and only needed a charge to justify the sentence (Mark 14:55).
6. There is no strong reason to consider the Sanhedrin Mishnah more reliable than the Gospel accounts if the two differ.

## Mark 14:55–59

- The trial of Jesus took place before the full high council, called the Sanhedrin in Greek. The council had seventy members and was led by the high priest. The Gospels describe the trial as a formal legal process:
- The council searched for witnesses (14:55).
- They heard testimony from eyewitnesses (14:56–59).
- They placed Jesus under oath (Matthew 26:63).
- They allowed Jesus to defend himself (Mark 14:60).
- The "high priest tore his clothes" (14:63).
- The Sanhedrin gave the final verdict (14:64).

This does not mean it was a fair trial. The decision to put Jesus to death had already been made. Evidence was not sought to determine the truth, but to obtain a guilty verdict and death sentence.

- False witnesses giving false testimony misrepresented what Jesus said about the destruction and rebuilding of the temple (see 15:29; John 2:19; Acts 6:14). Since the false witnesses contradicted each other, their testimony was not reliable (Numbers 35:30; Deuteronomy 17:6; 19:15).

## Mark 14:60–61

Because the false witnesses did not agree, the high priest asked Jesus for evidence against himself (14:56).

## Mark 14:62

- I am: Compare with study note on 6:49–50. Mark's audience has known from the beginning that Jesus was the Christ, the Son of God (1:1). This was acknowledged:
- by demons (1:24; 3:11; 5:7),
- by God (1:11; 9:7), and
- by the disciples (8:29–30).

But this is the first time that Jesus openly and publicly acknowledged that he was the Christ (the Messiah, God's chosen one).

- The second part of the reply Jesus gave was that he would sit at God's right hand, the place of power and honor. This pointed forward to his resurrection and ascension (Luke 24:50–51; Acts 1:9–11; see Philippians 2:9; Hebrews 1:3) and his triumphal coming on the clouds of heaven to judge the world.

At the return of Jesus, roles will be reversed. Those judging the Son of Man will be judged by him.

## Mark 14:63–64

The high priest tore his clothes after hearing the words of Jesus. This was a legal act that signaled a guilty verdict and showed that no more witnesses were needed. The rest of the Sanhedrin agreed that Jesus was guilty and deserved death.

It is not completely clear what the leaders considered to be blasphemy (showing disrespect toward God) in what Jesus said. It might have been his statement "I am," which is how God referred to himself in Exodus 3:14 (see John 8:58). However, Mark may not be repeating the exact words Jesus spoke at the trial (compare Matthew 26:64; Luke 22:70). The phrase could simply mean that Jesus was answering "yes" to the high priest's question. He was the Messiah, the Son of God.

During the second Jewish revolt against Rome, Bar Kokhba (AD 132–135) claimed to be the Messiah, and this was not treated as blasphemy. Jesus calling himself the Son of Man cannot have been considered blasphemous by itself. Before his trial, Jesus had used this title many times, and no charge of blasphemy had been raised.

However, the high priest and the Sanhedrin reacted strongly when Jesus identified himself as the Son of Man from Daniel 7:13. This indicated he was coming in God's name to judge the world.

This declaration came after:

- Jesus had already forgiven sins (Mark 2:5–7; Luke 7:48–50),
- claimed to be the Son of God (Mark 12:6),
- pronounced judgment on the temple (14:58), and
- claimed to be Lord of the Sabbath (2:28).

The religious leaders had already decided that Jesus should die. They now announced the guilty verdict they had already planned (14:55).

### Mark 14:65

- Spit: See 10:34.
- Prophesy: See 6:4, 15; 8:28; 14:58.
- Similar abuse would happen during his trial before Pontius Pilate (15:16–20).

### Mark 14:66–72

Peter's predicted denials occurred during the trial of Jesus (see 14:30).

### Mark 14:67

The title Jesus the Nazarene might have offended some people. People from Judea did not have a good opinion of those from Galilee (John 1:46; 7:41, 52).

### Mark 14:68

Peter said he did not know Jesus. To avoid more questions, he left the courtyard and went to the gateway.

### Mark 14:69–70

The servant girl repeated her accusation to standing there. The others thought Peter followed Jesus because he was a Galilean (see Matthew 26:73; compare Acts 2:7).

### Mark 14:71

When he denied knowing Jesus, Peter promised that he was telling the truth with an oath.

### Mark 14:72

When Peter denied Jesus for the third time, the rooster crowed again. This fulfilled the prediction of Jesus from 14:30.

While Jesus stood bravely before the Sanhedrin (the Jewish ruling council), Peter became afraid of people with little power. He called down curses on himself and said he did not know Jesus. When Peter remembered what Jesus had said, he began to weep.

### Mark 15:1

- Early in the morning: Roman trials usually began at the start of the day. It is uncertain if this was a second meeting of the whole Sanhedrin or if it refers back to the council's decision in 14:63–64 and resumes here.
- Since the Sanhedrin could not impose capital punishment (John 18:31), they took Jesus to Pilate, the Roman governor of Judea from AD 26–36. Pilate usually lived on the coast at Caesarea. But he stayed in Jerusalem during Passover. This was when Israel's celebration of the exodus event increased hopes for freedom from Roman rule.

### Mark 15:1–15

After Peter denied Christ , Mark returns to the story of Jesus and his trial. Pilate's hesitating under pressure matches what other sources say about his personality.

### Mark 15:2

- The phrase King of the Jews is similar to the Jewish title "King of Israel" in 15:32.
- You have said so: The response Jesus gives to Pilate's question appears in all four Gospels. Jesus clearly understood himself to be a king (10:37–38; 11:9–10; 12:35–37). Pilate eventually crucified him for this reason (15:26). But Pilate knew Jesus was not a political threat (John 18:33–39).

### Mark 15:3–5

Pilate asked Jesus to defend himself against the charges.

### Mark 15:6–8

- The custom described in 15:6–8 is not known outside of the Gospels, but all four Gospels mention it (Matthew 27:15–21; Luke 23:18–25; John 18:37–40). In many cases, ancient societies released prisoners during special holidays.
- Barabbas: See also Matthew 27:16–17; Luke 23:19.
- who had committed murder during the insurrection: Pilate's willingness to release Barabbas likely shows that Barabbas had not killed Roman citizens or soldiers (Matthew 15:15).

### Mark 15:9–14

Pilate wanted to release Jesus. However, the crowd became very angry and excited. They would not listen to reason or allow further discussion.

## Mark 15:15

- To satisfy the crowd: To protect his job, Pilate ordered the crucifixion of an innocent man.
- he had Jesus flogged: Flogging (severe beating) usually came before crucifixion. Soldiers used leather straps with pieces of metal, stone, or bone attached. These blows tore the skin and could even cause death.

This fulfilled what Jesus had predicted earlier in 10:34.

## Mark 15:16

the whole company: This was literally a cohort, which was one-tenth of a Roman legion of soldiers, or about 600 men. Those called to attend were likely all the soldiers on duty in the Praetorium.

## Mark 15:16–41

The crucifixion story is one of the most historically reliable events from ancient history. Why would the early church invent a story where its central figure died as a criminal? This story was offensive to Jews and seemed ridiculous to non-Jews (1 Corinthians 1:23).

## Mark 15:17

a purple robe: Purple cloth, made with an expensive dye, was worn by royalty and other wealthy individuals (Luke 16:19; 1 Maccabees 10:20, 62; 11:58). This purple robe might have been a centurion's old robe.

## Mark 15:18

King of the Jews: This was the official charge for which the Romans declared Jesus guilty (15:2, 26).

## Mark 15:21–22

- After they left the walled city of Jerusalem, Jesus became too weak to carry his cross. The Roman soldiers forced Simon of Cyrene (a city in northern Africa) to carry it (see Matthew 5:41).

Usually, a person being crucified had to carry the horizontal crossbeam (called the patibulum) to the place of execution. The vertical post (called the stipes) was often left in the ground as a warning to others (like a hangman's scaffold in a public square).

- Simon of Cyrene, the father of Alexander and Rufus: These men were probably known to Mark's audience (see Romans 16:13).
- Golgotha is an Aramaic word, meaning The Place of the Skull. In the Latin Vulgate, "skull" is calvariae ("Calvary"). In the time of Jesus, Golgotha was outside the walls of Jerusalem (John 19:20; see Matthew 27:32; Hebrews 13:12). When Herod Antipas later enlarged the city with the so-called third wall, Golgotha was enclosed.

## Mark 15:23

- It is uncertain if people offered Jesus wine mixed with myrrh as a kind act or to mock him (Proverbs 31:6). Jesus refused the calming drink mixture because he had committed himself to accept the suffering God had given him (Mark 10:38–39; 14:36).
- People have used myrrh since before the time of Jesus to treat wounds, infections, and digestive problems.

## Mark 15:24

- Crucifixion began with the Medes and Persians in the 600s BC. It spread to the eastern Mediterranean in the 300s BC through Alexander the Great. It became the main form of capital punishment in the Roman Empire until AD 337, when Constantine banned the practice.

Crucifixion was slow, shameful, and full of pain. Sometimes a victim stayed alive for several days. Birds and dogs might even begin to eat the body before the person died. A victim could be tied to the cross with ropes or fastened with nails. Nails were used in the crucifixion of Jesus (Luke 24:39; John 20:25, 27; see Colossians 2:14). To prevent early death from loss of breathing, a place to rest the feet or a seat was often added to the post.

- All four Gospels report that the soldiers divided his garments among themselves.

## Mark 15:25

Mark states that they crucified Jesus at the third hour, which is nine o'clock in the morning. John 19:14 mentions the time as around the sixth hour, or noon. These are approximate times. They would often describe events in the late morning as happening around the third hour (Matthew 20:3; Acts 2:15) or sixth hour (Mark 15:33; Matthew 20:5; 27:45; Luke 23:44; John 4:6; 19:14; Acts 10:9).

## Mark 15:26

Although the title King of the Jews was meant to mock Jesus, Mark presents it as true and full of meaning.

## Mark 15:27

two robbers: Jesus, the most important figure, was placed in the center. This position drew attention to him.

## Mark 15:29–32

- Jesus was being mocked and abused by those who passed by, the religious leaders, and those who were crucified with Jesus.
- those who passed by heaped abuse (literally they blasphemed): They shook their heads to show contempt (see Lamentations 2:15). They also mocked his claim that he would destroy the temple (see Mark 14:58).

## Mark 15:32

The two men who were crucified with Jesus also mocked him. One might expect them to show compassion, since they were suffering the same cruel punishment (see Luke 23:39–43).

## Mark 15:33

From the sixth hour until the ninth hour darkness came over all the land: The whole land likely refers to all of Judah. The darkness was both real and symbolic. It showed the evil nature of what was happening and gave a sign of the judgment that Jesus said would come on Israel (see 13:1–31; 14:58; 15:29).

## Mark 15:34

- Eloi, Eloi ... why have You forsaken me: Jesus cried out loudly. Mark records his words in Aramaic (the language Jesus spoke) and then gives the meaning in Greek.
- "My God, My God, why have you forsaken me?": Jesus is quoting Psalm 22:1. This statement should be understood by considering Mark 14:27, Psalm 22, Isaiah 53:10, 2 Corinthians 5:21, and Galatians 3:13. At this moment, God's purpose was being fulfilled. Jesus was giving his life as "a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45).

## Mark 15:35–36

The Aramaic word Eloi and the Hebrew form Eli (Matthew 27:46) sound similar to the name Elijah. Because of this, some people standing nearby thought Jesus was calling for the prophet Elijah to come and rescue him (see Malachi 4:5).

## Mark 15:37

The death of Jesus, like the crucifixion, is told with stark simplicity. The Gospel account gives only a few direct details.

## Mark 15:38

The veil of the temple ... torn in two might have been one of two curtains. It may have been the curtain that separated the sanctuary from the courtyard. This curtain was a large and beautiful tapestry about 23 meters tall (80 feet). Or it may have been the inner curtain that separated the Most Holy Place (the most sacred room) from the rest of the sanctuary.

If it was the outer curtain, people could have seen it tear (compare the "darkness" in 15:33). This would show that the prediction of Jesus about the destruction of the sanctuary (14:58; 15:29) was already beginning to happen in a spiritual way (see Rom 9–11). The full physical destruction would come later, in AD 70.

If it was the inner curtain, the tearing likely had a different meaning. Just as the heavens opened at the baptism of Jesus to show his direct access to God (see study note on Mark 1:10), his death now made that access possible for his followers (see Hebrews 6:19–20; 9:3–14; 10:19–20).

## Mark 15:39

- The centurion: The Latin word centurion refers to an officer in charge of 100 men.
- Jesus as the Son of God was announced by many voices. God declared it(1:11; 9:7). Demons also recognized it (1:24, 34; 3:11; 5:7). Mark states it at the beginning of the Gospel (1:1). Jesus himself speaks about it (12:6; 13:32; 14:61–62). Now, a Gentile (non-Jewish) officer also declares it.

## Mark 15:40–41

- These women helped meet some of the financial needs of Jesus (see Luke 8:2–3). They were present at the burial and the empty tomb (Mark 15:47; 16:1–8). They were the first to witness the resurrection of Jesus.
- Mary Magdalene was from the village of Magdala near the Sea of Galilee. She is a key figure in the resurrection stories (16:1, 9; Matthew 28:1; Luke 24:10; John 20:1, 11–18).
- Mary the mother of James the younger: This James might have been James son of Alphaeus (Mark 3:18).
- Salome is mentioned only here and in Mark 16:1.

## Mark 15:43–45

Joseph of Arimathea: He was possibly from Ramathaim, a village about 32 kilometers (20 miles) northwest of Jerusalem. A respected member of the Jewish high council (Sanhedrin), he was also a secret follower of Jesus. He was waiting for the kingdom of God to come (see Matthew 27:57; Luke 23:50–51; John 19:38). He bravely asked Pilate for the body of Jesus so he could bury it.

As a prominent Council member who was not known as a disciple, his request supported Rome's interests. This addressed Jewish concerns about leaving the dead exposed after sunset (Deuteronomy 21:22–23). It also prevented the disciples of Jesus from receiving the body.

## Mark 15:46

Joseph prepared the body of Jesus for burial and laid it in his own tomb (see Matthew 27:60).

## Mark 16:1

- At sunset, when the Sabbath day ended, the shops opened again. The women "bought spices so they could go and anoint the body of Jesus" (16:1). They intended to reduce the smell of the dead body.
- The women did not expect Jesus to resurrect from the dead. Even the empty tomb did not convince them of his resurrection (John 20:2, 11–15).

## Mark 16:3–4

The women wondered how to move the large stone covering the tomb. God had already moved the stone to let them and the other disciples enter.

## Mark 16:7

The angel's message to the disciples repeated what Jesus had already said (14:28). It reminded them of his promise.

The disciples had abandoned Jesus and denied him, but they would be forgiven. Their role as apostles (messengers sent by Jesus) would be restored.

## Mark 16:8

- The story ends with the women running away from the tomb. They were shaking with fear and confused (not sure what was happening).
- they did not say a word to anyone: This can be understood in two ways. It may be positive. The women may not have spoken to others because they were focused on their task to tell the disciples (16:7; compare Luke 10:4; 2 Kings 4:29).

Or it may be negative. The women may have failed to deliver the message at that moment (compare Luke 24:5–11; John 20:1–2, 18).

## Mark 16:9–20

Nearly all scholars agree that Mark did not write the shorter ending and the longer ending of his Gospel. These endings use different styles, vocabulary, and theology (teaching about God). Also, the two best early Greek manuscripts (Codex Sinaiticus and Codex Vaticanus) do not include these endings.

However, many scholars also doubt that Mark meant to end his Gospel at 16:8. Several reasons support this view:

1. Mark emphasizes that the predictions of Jesus are fulfilled. If the Gospel ends at 16:8, there is no account of Jesus appearing after his resurrection.
2. All the other Gospels include stories of Jesus appearing to the women and the disciples.
3. Some early manuscripts include added endings. This suggests that some early copyists (people who copied texts by hand) thought the Gospel needed a clearer ending.
4. There is no clear reason why Mark would choose to end at 16:8. Many suggested reasons come from modern ways of reading, not from how a first-century Christian writer would likely think.
5. The Gospel begins with a strong statement that Jesus is the Messiah (1:1), but ending at 16:8 would leave the story with fear instead of resolution.
6. The Greek word gar ("because") appears at the end of 16:8. It is very unusual for an ancient Greek book to end with this word.
7. Mark 16:7 suggests the disciples will meet Jesus in Galilee. If 16:8 was the original ending, it would be the only prediction in the Gospel that did not come true.

Because of these reasons, many scholars think the original ending was lost (for example, the last page may have been damaged or removed) or that Mark did not finish writing it.